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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

People of Bajura living in Kathmandu celebrating Bhuwa festival in Bhrikutimandap on Saturday.

12 killed in Bhaluwang bus accident

PM expresses sorrow over the road tragedy

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ghorahi, Jan. 13

As of 6 pm Saturday, a dozen people, 11 men and one woman, are confirmed to have died in the bus accident that occurred at Bhaluwang, Dang on Friday.

Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Janak Bahadur Malla informed that the Bhe 1 Kha 3912 bus belonging to the company Namaste Nepal Yatayat Pvt. Ltd. lost control and fell from the Rapti bridge into the Rapti River below at Bhaluwang, Rapti Rural Municipality-1. The accident happened at 10.30 pm Friday night when the bus was on its way from Nepalgunj to Kathmandu.

DSP Malla told The Rising Nepal that over speeding could have caused the tragedy. "Looking at the accident, it appears that high speed pushed the bus out of control," he said.

According to Malla, the bus also did not stop at the temporary traffic police check post near the bridge despite the cops asking the driver to.

However, the bus's driver Lal Bahadur Nepali, who is currently in police custody, has claimed that a faulty serpentine belt made the bus lose control and fall into the river. In addition to the



12 dead, 23 people were injured in the accident. Malla informed that they were being treated at Butwal and Kohalpur.

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has expressed sorrow over the accident and the demise of the passengers. Taking to social media on Saturday morning, Prime Minister Prachanda paid tribute to those who lost their lives and directed all the relevant government bodies to play an effective role in the rescue and treatment of the injured.

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has asked all concerned agencies to leave no stone unturned in treating the wounded and helping the survivors recover.

Challenges of fine tuning weather forecast accuracy

BY INDIRA ARYAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 13



Photo Courtesy: ICIMOD

TRN SPECIAL

Despite the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology predicting above-normal rainfall for this winter (December to February) in its seasonal weather forecast, no rainfall has been recorded so far.

Issuing a special bulletin, the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology (DHM) forecast a 55 to 65 per cent chance of above-average rainfall in the northeast parts of Sudurpaschim Province and the northern parts of Karnali Province during these winter months.

It also predicted a 45 to 55 per cent chance of above-average rainfall in the eastern and southern parts of Sudurpaschim Province, southern parts of Karnali Province, all parts of Lumbini Province except the eastern parts, Gandaki Province, northwest parts of Bagmati Province, and northeast parts of Koshi Province.

The meteorological department also stated a 35 to 45 per cent chance of above-average rainfall in western parts of Sudurpaschim Province, eastern parts of Lumbini Province, central and southern parts of Bagmati Province, western parts of Madhesh Province, and northwest of Koshi Province.

There is a 35 to 45 per cent chance of below-average rainfall in the southern parts of Koshi Province and the central and eastern parts of Mahesh Province during the period. Yet, almost two months into the winter season, there has been no sign of precipitation across the country.

According to DHM data, this is not the only year below-normal rainfall recorded.

Below-normal precipitation was recorded in 2016 (75% below normal), 2017 (60% below), 2018 (70% below), 2021 (76% below), and 2023 (79% below).

Why is the seasonal forecast questionable?

Bibuti Pokharel, Chief of the Climate Change Section under the DHM, mentioned that there is still one month left in the winter season this year. It is not yet time to determine whether the seasonal forecast has been true or not.

"Despite the absence of recorded rainfall thus far, our long-range forecast indicates discrepancies that we are actively studying. The seasonal outlook was formulated by integrating regional and global models, however, the forecast has exhibited uncertainty when compared to other countries. Additionally, predicting accurately poses a challenge due to our country's tropical structure and mountainous terrain," Pokharel said.

"In our current situation, we are also dealing with climate change issues, and predictions are not 100 per cent accurate in mountainous countries like ours where the impact of climate change has been more pronounced in recent years. Another concern is the lack of data for calibration observation. We are working slowly to find solutions," she said.

The seasonal outlook preparation just began in the 2020 monsoon, and we are currently in the fourth year of seasonal forecasting. "Due to a lack of technology and trained human resources, we have not divided the forecast into separate months. Forecasting for an entire season poses uncertainties. We are currently in discussions and planning to find a way to break down precipitation for each month," Pokharel said.

According to Sudarshan Humagain, a meteorologist at DHM, the forecast was not provided every month, it was given for the whole season. "If we need to forecast monthly or fortnightly, we do not have that technology in Nepal. We are only able to provide a seasonal outlook, and it may not be 100 per cent accurate as we are only providing qualitative information.

'Govt ready to alter track of East-West Railway'

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Narayangadh, Jan. 13

Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport, Prakash Jwala, has said that the government is ready to find alternatives to the East-West Electric Railway even though its initial mapping has been done. Speaking at a programme in Chitwan on Saturday, he made it clear that the government is ready to find an alternative to railways to address the issues and the problems of the concerned people.



Minister Prakash Jwala

"The government is also ready to find an alternative to the railway according to the demand of the people. The work of demarcation of the railway is going on. Recently people and representatives of Bharatpur Metropolitan City have informed me about their dissatisfaction regarding the demarcation of the project," said Minister Jwala, and iniformed that the government is looking into the issue.

Meanwhile, speaking at the discussion with Railway Victims Struggle Committee which was organised by the Bharatpur Metropolis, he said that the government should listen to the concerns and complaints of people.

Earlier, he had said that the government is committed to solving the problems encountered in the construction of railway during a press conference held at the Bharatpur Airport.

"We will draw a conclusion from the discussion, research and study. We will take a new decision after understanding the actual situation and the opinion of the people," said Minister Jwala.

He also informed that the demarcation work has been stopped until a new decision has been made due to the opposition of the public.

According to the preliminary mapping done by the Department of Railway, the railway will enter Chitwan from Hetaunda from south of the East-West Highway and reach Amarapuri of Nawalparasi (East).

It will go through ward numbers 8, 7, 5, and 4 of Bharatpur. However, the locals of these wards have been protesting against the mapping of the project.

Similarly, he also said that the construction of road has faced glitches due to the lack of budget as the ceiling of the budget to the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport (MoPIT) was reduced by Rs. 37 billion in the current Fiscal Year 2023/24.

Minister Jwala said that the MoPIT is in the process to identify the problems and demand additional budget from the Ministry of Finance to solve them.

He claimed that the construction works of roads and bridges in Narayangadh-Butwal, Narayangadh-Mugling, and Narayangadh-Gondrang have progressed rapidly and they will be completed soon.

» SEE PAGE 6

EC allots election symbols to NA member candidates

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

The Election Commission on Saturday provided election symbols to candidates of the National Assembly election slated for January 25.

In line with the election schedule, offices of the election officers in all seven provinces provided election symbols to respective party candidates.

Commission spokesperson Shaligram Sharma Poudel informed that provincial offices provided election symbols from 10.00 am to 1.00 pm on Saturday. Altogether 51 candidates from eight political parties are competing in the election after one candidate withdrew his candidacy from among 52.

The EC said finally five candidates each in Koshi Province and Madhes



Province, 15 in Bagmati, eight in Gandaki and six in Lumbini, Karnali and Sudurpachim are in the fray.

A total of 52 candidates had filed their nomination papers for the NA election under various categories on January 9. Seventeen candidates in the women category, six in the Dalit category eight under persons with disabilities or minority communities and 21 from other groups had registered their candidacy. One from other groups had withdrawn the candidacy.

New Nepal-made tractors hit market

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

A new brand of tractors made in Nepal has hit the market.

Chandragiri Machinery Udhyog has begun the production and distribution of Chandragiri Tractors with the capacity of 6HP and 9HP. The company launched the new products at the Agri-Mechinery Exhibition 2080, held in Pokhara a week ago. The mini tractor with a new look bearing Nepali brand had drawn the attention of many at the expo.

What surprised many in Pokhara during the launch of the product was its price. The simple-looking 6 HP tractor is priced at just Rs. 175,000 while the 6HP comes at Rs. 200,000. The company has coloured the machine parrot green which has made the product attractive and cool.



Chandragiri has conducted a year-long test with the tractors before launching them in the market. Within a couple of days of the product hitting the market, the company has received demand for as many as 50 tractors.

"We have got many inquiries and bookings for the newly launched tractor. People have shown love to the domestic product," said Gaurav Shrestha, Managing Director of the company.

However, the company can produce only 15 pieces of tractors a month. Shrestha said that the capacity would be enhanced if the demands went up. He claimed that the new tractor gives better mobility, safety and durability compared to the two-wheel tractors currently available in the market.

Chandragiri tractors feature four wheels, a comfortable seat for the driver, a fuel tank, and a roof. It can carry goods by affixing a trolley, plough field and perform many other agricultural work.

The company has been producing agricultural inputs for a decade while it has been in the trading of agricultural machinery for more than one and a half decades. It recently launched millet cleaning machines and grading machines as well.

» SEE PAGE 6

Demand for yams peaks ahead of Maghe Sankranti

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 13



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Women choosing yam at the Kalimati market. Demand for roots, including yam, has gone up over the past few days for the coming Maghe Sankranti festival.

Demand for roots, including yam, cocoyam and sweet potatoes, has been growing in the market for the past few days ahead of the Maghe Sankranti that falls on Monday. People consume various kinds of yams, either boiled or with some condiments, while marking the Maghe Sankranti festival. They boil the yam on the last day of Poush and eat it the next morning with ghee, chaku and sakhkhar.

Almost a dozen varieties of yams are available in the market. The yam varieties known as Hattipaile, Ban Tarul, Seto Ghar Tarul, Pani Tarul, Patale Tarul and Simal Tarul, among others, can be seen in the market these days. The prices of the yams vary based on their varieties.

Gita Adhikari of Gatthaghar, Bhaktapur said that she bought five kilograms of yam and two kilograms of cocoyam worth Rs. 1,380 Saturday morning. "I purchased two kilograms of Patale Tarul at 250 per kilogram, three kilograms of Seto Tarul at Rs. 100 per kilogram and two kilograms of Ban Tarul at Rs. 200," she said.

Similarly, she said that she purchased two kilograms of cocoyam at Rs. 90 per kg. She said that the price of yams varied from shop to shop. The price per kg of yam stood at Rs. 90 to Rs. 250 in the retail market, she said, adding that the price of Patale was highly expensive compared to other varieties of yams.

A retailer of Gatthaghar, Bhaktapur Sanjaya Shrestha said that he was selling yams at Rs. 90 to Rs. 250 per kilo based on their quality. Large number of consumers tend to buy yams which are available at Rs. 80-150 per kg. The flow of consumers to purchase roots, including yam, sweet potatoes and cocoyam has increased in the markets from Friday.

"I am selling a kilo of Hattipaile at Rs. 100, Patale at Rs. 250, Bantarul at Rs. 200, Simal at Rs. 90 and yam supplied from Sarlahi at Rs. 80 per kg," he said. The demand for Patale and Ban Tarul is very low compared to other varieties due to high rates while the demand for yam of Sarhali is high. A consumer normally buys around 3-5 kilograms of yam as per their choice and price, he said.

The price of per kilogram of yam ranges from a minimum Rs. 70 to the maximum of Rs. 200 at wholesale market, said Binaya Shrestha, information officer of Kalimati Fruit and Vegetable Market Development Board (KFVMDB). He said the Patale and Ban Tarul variety were being sold at above Rs. 200 per kg which makes it the most expensive variety of yam currently available in the market.

Another variety of yam, which is supplied from Sarlahi district, is being sold at Rs. 70 per kg. This is the cheapest variety in the wholesale market. The price of yams has increased by Rs. 10 per kg this year compared to last year, he said, adding that the price of yam might be increased further by up to Rs. 10-20 per kg on Sunday and Monday as the demand for yams would be high these days.

Shrestha, however, said the price of yam would start to decrease after Maghe Sankrati as the demand for yam would drastically drop. He said that the transaction of yam has been increasing day by day for the last few days as it is the main season to consume the item.

The domestic production of yam is enough to meet the demand this season, he said, adding that more than 70 per cent of yam in Kathmandu is supplied from Sarlahi district and the rest is supplied from other districts.

Daily around 150-200 tonnes of yam is being supplied from various districts, including Sarlahi, Dolakha, Palpa, Dhading, Ilam, Dhankuta, Kavrepalanchowk and various parts of Tarai districts to the Kathmandu Valley for the last three days.

Around 1,221 tonnes of yam entered the Kalimati market by Saturday of the month of Poush, according to KFVMDB. Similarly, around 101 tonnes of cocoyam and 261 tonnes of sweet potato entered the Kalimati market during the period.

ONLY 15% LAND IRRIGATED IN BAGLUNG

RSS
Dhorpatan (Baglung), Jan. 13

Only 15.15 per cent of the arable land in the district has irrigation facilities. The district has a total of 178,400 hectares of land, of which 46,148 hectares is being cultivated. A total of 6,790 hectares of land have been irrigated till now, while the area with irrigation facility throughout the year is 2,815 hectares, according to Head of Water Resources and Irrigation Development Division Office, Baglung, Surendra Paudel.

A large budget is needed to provide irrigation facilities to all the land due to geographical difficulties in Baglung, adds Paudel. This year the Gandaki province and the federal government have planned to invest Rs 222 million in Baglung. Altogether 104 schemes of the province and 20 schemes of the federal government are under implementation in the current financial year.

Chief Paudel said the demand for irrigation schemes has increased and although the office aims to provide access to irrigation in all areas irrigation schemes are now being implemented in fields where rice and wheat are cultivated. After the access to irrigation, the area under paddy cultivation has also increased.

Baglung is yet to become self-sufficient in food. Balibhadra Gharti, a farmer of Nisikhola Rural Municipality-5 in the district says that the production has decreased due to the lack of irrigation. Maize tops among the cereals produced by the district, where it is grown on more than 20,000 hectares. Likewise, Millet is cultivated on 18,000 and wheat on 7,000 hectares.

According to Agriculture Knowledge Centre Baglung, although paddy was planted in more than 6,000 hectares of land last year only 18,690 metric tons of paddy was harvested. This year, 20,551 metric tons of paddy has been produced by growing it in an area of 5,717 hectares.

Govt committed to promote handicraft sector: DPM Shrestha

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister, Narayan Kaji Shrestha, has said the government was committed to promoting handicraft sector as it has been significantly contributing to country's economy.

Addressing the 43rd annual general meeting of the Federation of Handicrafts Associations here today, DPM Shrestha shared that the draft of handicraft policy would be given a final shape soon and high -level discussion forwarded for the construction of handicrafts village in all seven provinces.

He underscored that rapid economic development is national urgency and added the government was effortful for the same. The DPM mentioned that the government has been moving ahead by keeping good governance, prosperity and social justice in centre. "Development and economic activities have been kept in priority. Good governance is its precondition," he underlined.

> The need of introducing different projects to attract young generation in the handicraft sector. This sector has a significant contribution in reducing trade deficit.

Presenting the fact that country's economy could be strengthened by exporting handicraft items, Minister for Industry, Commerce, Land and Administration of Bagmati Province, Ram Krishna Chitrakar, said Bagmati province was ready to facilitate in export promotion.

Similarly, President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry, Chandra Prasad Dhakal, explained that FNCCI was ready to collaborate with the government.

Chairperson of Nepal Chamber of Commerce, Rajendra Malla, pointed out the need of introducing different projects to attract young generation in the handicraft sector. This sector has a significant contribution in reducing trade deficit.

Senior Vice-President of Confederation of Nepalese Industries, Birendra Raj Pandey, laid emphasis that the government should facilitate in export promotion. Stating that handicraft sector enhances the art and culture, earns national image in the international community, he pointed out the need of support from all sided to this regard.

Moreover, Chancellor of the Nepal Academy of Fine Arts, Naradmani Hartamchhali, shared that the Academy was active to give esthetic value to the handicraft goods, while Executive Director of Trade and Export Promotion Centre, Sharad Bikram Rana, suggested the entrepreneurs to produce goods that compete in the global market.

Deputy-Mayor of Lalitpur Metropolitan City, Manjali Shakya, stressed support of all three-tier governments in development of handicraft sector. Federation President Prachanda Shakya requested for concessional loan to promote handicraft business.

NEA restores power supply to 23 industries having dues of trunk lines

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 13



The Nepal Electricity Authority has reconnected electricity supply lines of industries that were cut due to non-payment of tariff for dedicated feeders and trunk lines on Friday midnight. Manoj Silwal, deputy managing director of NEA, the Authority connected the lines of all 23 industries that were cut due to non-payment of trunk and dedicated line dues last night.

He said that the NEA connected the electricity supply as per the government direction and the decision of the board of directors of the NEA. The meeting of the Council of Ministers held last Tuesday decided to form a probe committee to resolve the disputes of dedicated feeders and trunk lines electricity arrears and reconnect power supply of these industries immediately.

The government formed a three-member probe committee headed by former judge Girish Chandra Lal to address the disputes relating to dedicated and trunk lines. On Friday, the meeting of the board of directors of the NEA chaired by Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation Shakti Bahadur Basnet decided to connect the power supply of the industries whose power supply had been severed.

Earlier, the private sector requested the government to immediately reconnect the electricity of those industries whose lines had been cut citing that there are arrears without actual base and proof or non-payment of tariff.

The Authority had cut the lines of 24 industries with arrears of more than Rs. 50 million for electricity supply through the dedicated and trunk lines.

In the first phase, the NEA disconnected electricity of four industries, including Jagadamba, Reliance Spinning Mills, Ghorahi Cement and Arghakhanchi Cement on December 22, 2023. Then after, the NEA had cut power supply of Ashok Steels, Triveni Spinning Mills, Sarbottam Cement, Laxmi Steel and Sonapur Spinning Mills.

The NEA had disconnected the electricity supply of Baba Jute Mills, Nigale Cement, Triveni Synthetic Yarn Industries, Himal Iron and Steel, Jagdamba Enterprises, Hama Iron and Everest Paper Mills.

Similarly, electricity supply of Cosmos Cement, Shubhashree Agni Cement, Jagdamba Synthetic, Gharana Foods, Siddhartha PET Plast, Butwal Cement, Narayani Ispat and Hulas Steels was also stalled.

Out of these, Himal Steel has pledged to pay the outstanding amount in installments and after paying the first installment, the Authority had already connected the line. According to the Authority, 61 industries have to pay Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears.

Dry spell bodes ill for crop yield in Rukum

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rukum East, Jan. 13



PHOTO: TRN

Snowless Mountain.

Gana Bahadur Budha of Bhume Rural Municipality-2 has already started to worry about a famine this year. He is worried about the reduction in production of winter crops, including wheat and barley, due to lack of rain and snow.

Budha said that even after completion of the second week of January, wheat, barley and vegetable crops started to dry up due to lack of rain and snow.

He, who is waiting for winter rains and snowfall, said that if the weather in the district remains the same, crop yield will be affected in the mountain. He said, "Last year, at the beginning of December, the yard was covered with snow. Now, no snow has been seen until mid-January."

"The drought has made it dry. Drought has also caused extreme cold," he said. It has not rained since last October. Locals are worried because barley, wheat crops and even garden vegetables have started to dry due to the long drought.

Udaya Ram Roka of Putha Uttarganga Rural Municipality-5 said that neither rain nor snow has been experienced for a long time. Until two to four years ago, snow used to cover villages and hills in the month of December. He said that there was no snow or rain until the second week of January. Roka said that fruits and cereals don't grow until it snows.

Farmers said that due to the dry spell, barley and wheat sown in fields in October-November have not sprouted yet.

Since there is no rain from October to January, the water sources have also started drying up. Even the locals who are fully dependent on herbs in the high mountain settlements are still waiting for the snowfall.

Locals have experienced that herb production also declines in years without heavy snow. Dambar Budha of Sisne Rural Municipality-1 said that Yarsagumba, Katuki Bholte, Chiraito, and Gucci mushrooms grow well in the year when there is a lot of snow.

Budha said, "In the year when there is snow, the production of herbs increases along with grain crops, but in the year when there is no snow, the production declines."

Minister Gurung stresses quake-resilient infrastructures

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

Minister for Urban Development, Sita Gurung, emphasized building quake-resilient structures to ensure development of sustainable infrastructures.

At the national conference organized by the central committee of Diploma Engineers Association Nepal (DEAN) here today, Minister Gurung underscored post-quake reconstruction of physical infrastructures in a way that reduces quake damages.

Stating that the role of engineers and technical human resources was important to make sustainable infrastructures, the Minister called for effective enforcement of the criteria and laws as stipulated in the National Building Code.

She also pledged to forge cooperation for institutionalization of the DEAN. Need of diversity is also felt in the engineering sector, the Minister reminded.

Similarly, Secretary at the Ministry of Water Supply, Suresh Acharya, suggested that risk of disaster could be minimized by considering improvement in the quality of physical infrastructures.

According to him, participation of technicians was necessary at local level for effective implementation of federalism. He pressed for establishment of engineering administrative staff college for development and enhancement of engineers' skills recruited in the civil service.

DEAN's Advisor Dr Rajendra Prasad Adhikari presented a working paper that shed light on the roles of technicians in the construction of sustainable infrastructures.

Similarly, Coordinator of the DEAN Technical Committee, Engineering Khadka KC, highlighted the need for cooperation and collaboration among the government, development technicians and local communities for sustainable infrastructure development.

Nepal Aushadhi Ltd. set to produce additional 20 types of medicines

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

Amid the ongoing challenges posed by the global pandemic, Nepal Aushadhi Limited, a government-owned pharmaceutical company in Nepal, is gearing up to address the growing demand for essential medicines. In particular, the company has set its sights on lessening the shortage of Paracetamol in the market.

The reliability of white-coloured Paracetamol has made it a sought-after choice among consumers, leading to increased demand nationwide. Recognizing the need for a robust response, Nepal Aushadi Limited, the parent company, is embarking on an ambitious plan to expand its production and contribute to public welfare.

Under the directive of Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda,' Nepal Aushadhi Ltd. is set to produce an additional 20 types out of 98 essential medicines for free distribution to the public. The move comes as a strategic response to ensure the availability of critical drugs during these challenging times.

Kailash Kumar Paneru, the General Manager of Nepal Aushadhi Ltd., informed that the company is actively preparing to meet the heightened demand by producing medicines locally. The initiative has received the support of the Ministry of Finance, which is disbursing over Rs. 247.8 million to facilitate the expansion of the company's production capacity.



FILE PHOTO: TRN
The logo of Nepal Aushadhi Limited in Kathmandu.

In a collaborative effort, agreements have been inked between the Ministry of Industry and Nepal Aushadhi Ltd. to enhance the institutional capacity of the pharmaceutical company. The funds provided will be utilized for the purchase of raw materials, machinery, and the renovation and expansion of production amenities.

Nepal Aushadhi Ltd. aims to meet the current demand by diversifying its product offerings. Previously known for producing 146 types of medicines, the company shifted its focus to the production of Cetamol. However, the recent plan includes diversification in production and investments to stay competitive in the market.

Acknowledging the challenges of navigating a competitive market, General Manager Paneru expressed confidence that the expansion of the company's capacity will position it to compete effectively with other drugs available in the market. He emphasized the readiness of Nepal Aushadhi Ltd. to provide quality medicines, stating that collaboration with local levels across the country will be integral to enhancing the distribution strategy.

Looking ahead, Nepal Aushadhi Ltd. plans to convert its existing space into a self-generating complex, establishing a 'medical hub' to operate commercially. This strategic move aims to further expand production operations and enhance the company's competitiveness.

Paneru highlighted the government's primary objective is to produce and distribute 98 types of medicines for public access. The company's commitment to reducing the reliance on imported pharmaceuticals aligns with recent statistics from the Trade and Export Promotion Centre, revealing imports of pharmaceuticals worth NPR 16.08 billion in the current fiscal year.

As the company progresses with its expansion plans, Nepal Aushadhi Ltd. envisions contributing significantly to the reduction of the annual import bill for medicinal products, thereby bolstering Nepal's self-reliance in the pharmaceutical sector.

Hand-woven bamboo baskets losing out race to plastic ware

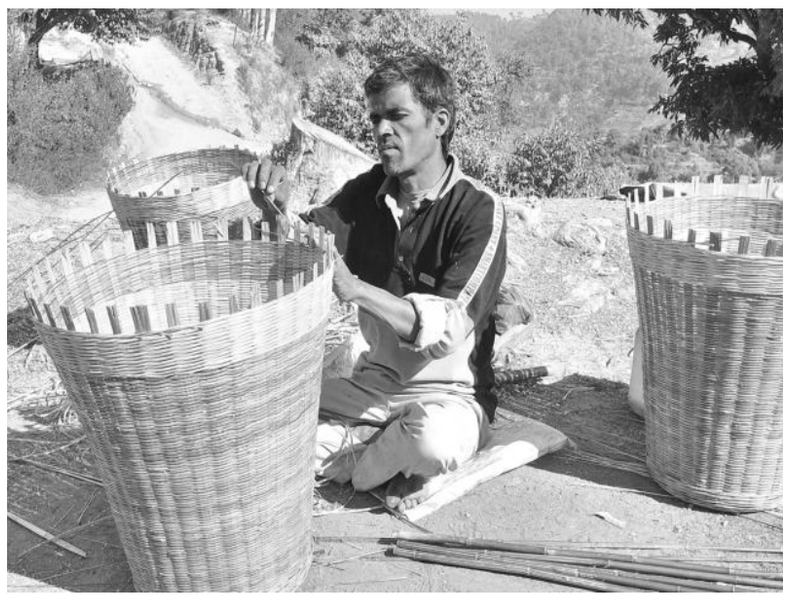


PHOTO: DIL BAHADUR SINGH/TRN
Dabal BK of KI Singh Rural Municipality weaving bamboo baskets.

BY DIL BAHADUR SINGH
Doti, Jan. 13

Dabal BK, 45, of KI Singh Rural Municipality, has been earning livelihood by weaving bamboo baskets for more than 25 years. Lately, it has been difficult for him to generate income through the vocation that he continued for more than two decades.

Easily available plastic wares are on the verge of displacing eco-friendly bamboo baskets. He said, "It takes a day to weave a single basket and it costs around Rs.600.

We don't make much profit since the selling price is very low compared to the effort that takes to weave a basket. Meanwhile, people started buying plastic wares as plastic wares are cheaper compared to hand-woven bamboo baskets."

Raibhan Thakulla, 55, from Bagleg of Purbichauki Rural Municipality, shares a similar story. He said bamboo was easily available in Bagleg as it was connected with Khaptad National Park. The increased use of plastic goods after the area was connected to the road network displaced bamboo baskets."

He said, "In the past, people used to come looking for bamboo products like baskets, but nowadays, it is difficult to find customers."

Bamboo is not easily available in all areas of the district. People need to risk entering in jungle to pick bamboo. Meanwhile, governmental and non-governmental organisations have not taken any initiatives to commercialise traditional skills.

As a result, people engaged in the bamboo weaving business were left with no option but to discontinue the work as it was difficult for hand-woven goods to compete with plastic goods.

People suggest that local authorities should formulate policies to promote the use of locally produced materials. Ram Bahadur Dhami of Bogatan Phudsil Rural Municipality, said, "We have started using bamboo baskets as dustbins in our ward. To support locally produced goods other local levels too should give impetus to such initiatives.

All local bodies in the district are connected with road networks. Along with easy access to road transportation in rural areas, the use of plastic materials has intensified.

We should promote bamboo products owing to their eco-friendly and biodegradable nature.

APPROPRIATE STANDARDS STRESSED FOR CONSTRUCTION OF POLICE STATIONS

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Jan. 13

Koshi Province Minister for Internal Affairs and Law Rameshwor Rai has announced the formulation of standards for the construction of police stations and police offices in the province.

During the inspection of the Traffic Police Office which is under construction in Damak of Jhapa, Minister Rai said that the current standards set by the federal government posed a financial burden for the province. He said that there was no need to construct extravagant office blocks for police stations with a small number of officers on duty.

According to the existing standards, more than Rs. 28 million is required to construct a single police station.

Minister Rai said that the provincial government would prioritise completing pending works instead of building new police stations, and construction work would only proceed once the new standards were formulated.

He said that the provincial government was making technical preparations for the provincial police operation along with discussions with retired high-ranking officers, former home ministers and others related to security matters.

Additionally, Minister Rai said that the provincial government had been attentive towards the ongoing construction of the Damak Traffic Police Office building.

The construction of the three-storied building which began four years ago on May 6, 2019, at Rs. 28.32 million has not been completed yet. Minister Rai assured to provide the necessary budget for the construction of the Damak Traffic Police Office which is in limbo.

Rishing Municipality Chair Shrestha using his vehicle as ambulance



PHOTO: AMAR RAJ NAHARKI/TRN
Locals of Rishing Rural Municipality using the vehicle of Bharat Krishna Shrestha as an ambulance.

BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Jan. 13

In an admirable display of public service, Bharat Krishna Shrestha, the chairperson of Rishing Rural Municipality-5, Tanahun, has been using his private vehicle as an ambulance to assist patients in need. Unlike some representatives who have faced criticism for the misuse of government facilities, Shrestha not only refrains from using official vehicles but actively contributes to the betterment of the community.

Shrestha, who also serves as the driver himself, employs his car to transport patients, showcasing a selfless commitment to the welfare of people in his constituency. Furthermore, he allocates allowances and facilities received from the ward for the treatment of financially disadvantaged individuals. Shrestha's exemplary actions have garnered praise, with more than 20 patients rescued and their treatment expenses covered over the past year.

A notable incident involved the prompt rescue of 82-year-old Santamaya Thapa, who had fallen and broken her leg.

Shrestha immediately responded, transporting her to Gandaki Hospital in Pokhara free of charge in his private vehicle. Despite an injury that prevented him from participating in a scheduled event, Shrestha prioritized the well-being of the community.

Addressing his dedication, Shrestha highlighted the lack of ambulance availability in the village and the economic challenges faced by the residents, prompting him to offer free transportation services. He mentioned that he has been spending over one lakh per month for the service of the people and emphasized that, for him, politics is about serving the people rather than earning a salary.

Shrestha entered politics with the aspiration to fulfil his father's dream of providing development opportunities to the villagers. Elected as ward chairman independently, Shrestha has gained praise for his dedication to community service.

Deepa Thapa Magar from Rishing Rural Municipality-8 has expressed her gratitude to Shrestha for rescuing her after she was bitten by a venomous snake last year.

Shrestha used his jeep, bearing the number Ba 8 Cha 8990, as an ambulance, further showcasing his commitment to community welfare. Shrestha actions reinforced his dedication to the welfare of the people.

Liver transplant successful on 3-year-old child

RSS
Bhaktapur, Jan. 13

The Martyr Dharmabhakta National Transplant Centre (Human Organ Transplant Centre) in Bhaktapur has successfully transplanted liver on a three-year-old patient for the first time, making the Centre self-reliant in liver transplant.

The 30-year-old mother of the toddler originally from Birgunj, Parsa donated her liver to her son, said Dr Pukar Chandra Shrestha, Centre's executive director and senior transplant surgeon. Dr Shrestha, under whose leadership the transplant on the toddler was conducted, shared that the health condition of the toddler was normal at present.

The Centre had not performed transplant of liver on such a young kid earlier, according to Dr Shrestha. The Centre at present performs four liver transplants in four consecutive days in a week, he informed.

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The Centre, established by the government in 2012, had first successfully transplanted kidney in 2016 with technical assistance from transplant surgeons from South Korea making it the first centre in the country to accomplish feat.

Later, critical surgery was being performed in the Centre with the assistance from surgeons from India. The Centre now independently conducts organ transplant on the patients by the team of Nepali surgeons.

Over 1,200 patients have undergone liver transplants since its establishment.

'Construction of hydropower project by drying up river objectionable'

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Myagdi, Jan. 13

Locals of Chim Khola Village in Raghuganga Rural Municipality-7, Myagdi demanded that the infrastructure in the village should not be damaged during the construction of hydropower projects. They made such demand after the Mona Hydropower Company initiated preparations to build the 5.5 Megawatt Bagar Khola Hydropower Project in the Bagar Khola River which flows through the village.

Ward chair Thakan Bahadur Paija informed that the locals objected to the project being constructed by drying up the river stating that it would have an adverse effect on the environment. He said that the project was introduced without consulting the locals.

> Paija informed that the locals objected to the project being constructed by drying up the river stating that it would have an adverse effect on the environment. He said that the project was introduced without consulting the locals.

He said, "We don't object to the construction of the hydroelectric project, but we cannot allow the project to be built by disrupting the flow of the river. We must find an alternative." Villagers said that the river would lose its existence if the project gets started.

Meanwhile, locals complained that the hydropower company tried to start the project without consulting people living in the affected area.

Mona Hydropower Company chair Chakra Thapa informed that they were trying to advance the project with the leadership of non-residential Myagdi people and requested cooperation in the matter.

The Mona Hydropower had done agreement with the Nepal Electricity Authority to generate electricity by mid-March 2027 and sell electricity at the rates of 8.40 per unit during the winter and 4.80 per unit during summer.

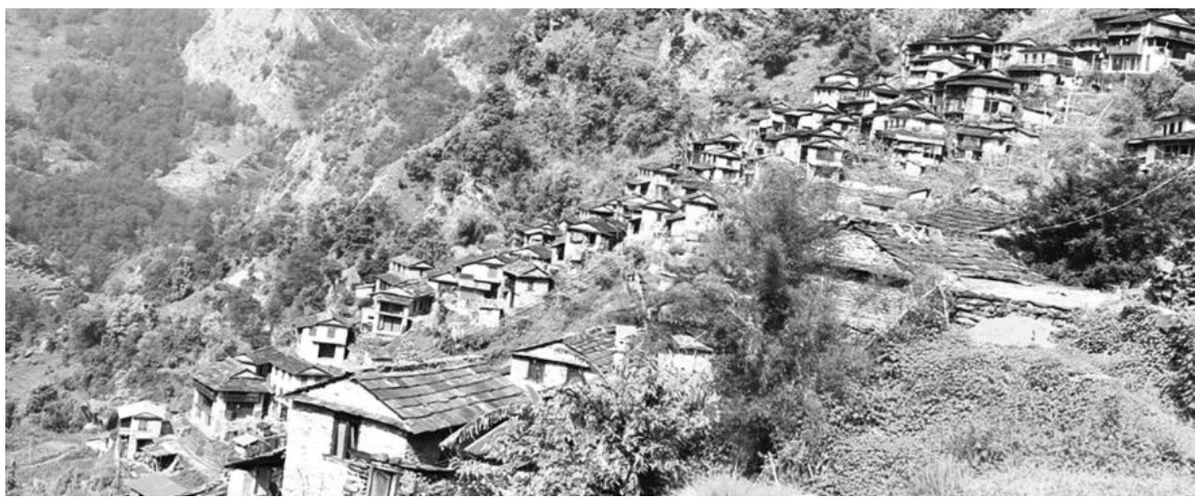


PHOTO: THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA/TRN
A view of scenically beautiful Chim Khola Village in Raghuganga Rural Municipality-7, Myagdi.

EDITORIAL

Cold Wave Threat In Tarai

Extreme weather phenomena are increasing due to the impact of global warming and climate change. And the recent spate of cold wave gripping the Tarai belt is one of these climate extremities affecting people, especially the vulnerable groups. Prolonged spell of dense fog that deprives the plains of the warm sun light has sent temperatures tumbling and lack of light and heat for the past few days has affected the normal life along the Tarai region, including Banke and Dhanusha districts. Children, senior citizens and people from impoverished communities like Musahar, Dom and Chamar are hardest hit by the ongoing wave of freezing cold. As a result, schools have been shut down, number of service seekers in government offices have fallen significantly and the movement of people during morning and evening hours too has gone down significantly.

Most of the flights to the Tarai based airports are getting canceled owing to poor visibility caused by foggy condition. This has increased high chance of the outbreak of cold-related illnesses such as pneumonia and influenza. In such a situation, it is advisable to keep warm and drink warm water. The districts across the Tarai region witness this phenomenon every year, with the poorest of the poor lacking adequate preparedness owing to their poverty and absence of awareness. The government should take this situation seriously and take proactive steps for the safety of the people concerned.

The people most affected by cold waves are the poor and daily wage earners who on the one hand lack preparations for the winter owing to their poverty and on the other hand when the cold wave hits, they lose jobs due to decreased human activities. This section of people lack both enough food and clothes to keep themselves warm during winter. They are reported to have been using jute sacks filled with straw to keep themselves warm. The cases of cold-related ailments like pneumonia are surging in the Tarai districts. Children, elderly and people with chronic diseases are most affected.

As per the information given by the field office of the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology at Ranjha, the temperature of Nepalgunj has been falling over the past few days. On Thursday and Friday, the temperatures dropped even further, and hovered around 7.7 to 9 degrees Celsius. The Chief District Officer and Coordinator of the District Disaster Management Committee of Banke says that the local level authorities have been mobilised to make necessary arrangements in their respective municipalities to protect the citizens from the cold, but the preparations still seem to be inadequate. Likewise, the Madhes government has planned to distribute 20,000 blankets to people affected by extreme cold. The government needs to be more sensitive about the pains and sufferings of the people, and if it has plans to distribute relief aid, that should be timely.

People in the Tarai, especially those from lower strata are in dire need of assistance, and the government should spring into urgent action instead of just collecting the data of the needy. Before this, there were reports of the people dying of cold in the quake-affected area of Jajarkot which calls for relief assistance without wasting time. The government needs to be more sensitive about the protection of the lives of people living at risk and distribute relief materials like warm clothes and blankets before it is too late. Medical manpower should also be made available to deal with cold-related illnesses.

P.N. Shah's Place In History

PARMESHWAR DEVKOTA

In a long human history, two types of kings ruled in the world - either the kings such as Cyrus the Great, Darius the Great or Ashurbanipal, king Sennacherib and alike. In our context, as we overthrew the Shah Dynasty and established the federal democratic republic after steady struggle and countless sacrifices, we have been ironically divided on the contribution of Prithvi Narayan (P.N.) Shah who unified small principalities into a great Nepal with his astute military strategy and people-centric campaign. But, some historians and so-called intellectuals see terror and forced annexation in it, comparing him with the kings of Assyria Ashurbanipal (668-627BC).

Defeating the Elamite king Humban Heltas in Susa, cruel king Ashurbanipal accounted his atrocities, "Susa, the great holy city, abode of their gods, seat of their mysteries, I conquered. I entered its palaces, I opened their treasures where silver, gold goods and wealth were amassed. I destroyed their Ziggurat (temple) of Susa. I smashed its sharing copper horns. I reduced the temple of Elam to naught.''

On the other hand, another group of historians compare P.N. Shah with Cyrus the Great and Darius the Great, arguing that he worked to unify the country tactfully. They say that the then divided states and people had different languages, cultures and traditions, but P.N. Shah and his soldiers were sensitive about respecting the different traditions and practices. P.N. Shah spared long-practiced Kipat system in the Limbuwan. This allowed the community to have the ownership of various types of lands and natural resources such as farm field, pasture, forest, rives and minerals.

The historians of this group claim that P.N. Shah was so lenient with the defeated principalities and their citizens. He seldom intimidated those communities and nurtures the mentality of conquering them. Rather, he tried to convince the principalities to join the unification drive so as to be more secure and uphold cultures, customs and religions.

In the pre-historic times, Darius had organised his empire into administrative regions and introduced coinage and started new monetary system and road linkage in his territory and uniformity in the use of Old Persian language. P.N. Shah also followed similar path of nation-building. Similarly, Cyrus the Great was also tolerant toward the Babylonian people. In that period, the Jewish people were captive in the Babylonia. Cyrus, by defeating the King of Babylonia, not only freed the Jewish people and let them return to their homeland, Jerusalem, but also, assured them to help build their temple. So, the Jewish Bible cites name of the Cyrus the Great as a liberator.

Like Cyrus the Great, P.N. Shah assimilated with the people of Kathmandu Valley in no time and sought easy compromise with the principalities of Koshi area. Had P.N. Shah not died at the age of 52 years in Devighat, he would have expanded the country to a significant size. With this conclusion, we began celebrating the birth anniversary of P.N. Shah and the National Unification Day again.

Building Community With Shared Future

Chen Song



The China Central Conference on Work Relating to Foreign Affairs was held in Beijing on December 27-28, 2023. Xi Jinping, General Secretary of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of China (CPC), President of the People's Republic of China and Chairman of the Central Military Commission, attended the conference and delivered an important address. President Xi presented a systematic review of the historic achievements and valuable experience of major-country diplomacy with Chinese characteristics in the new era, gave a profound exposition on the international environment and historical mission of China's external work on the new journey, and made comprehensive plans for China's external work for the present and coming periods.

It was pointed out at the conference that building a community with a shared future for mankind is the core tenet of Xi Jinping Thought on Diplomacy. It is how China proposes to solve the questions of what kind of world to build and how to build it based on the deepening understanding of the laws governing the development of human society. In summary, in building a community with a shared future for mankind, the goal is to build an open, inclusive, clean and beautiful world of lasting peace, universal security and shared prosperity. The pathway is promoting global governance that features extensive consultation and joint contribution for shared benefit, the guiding principle is to apply the common values of humanity, the basic underpinning lies in building a new type of international relations, the strategic guidance comes from the implementation of the Global Development Initiative, the Global Security Initiative and the Global Civilisation Initiative, and the platform for action is high-quality Belt and Road cooperation.

World harmony

On this basis, China seeks to bring countries together to meet challenges and achieve prosperity for all, and usher in a bright future of peace, security, prosperity and progress for the world. The tenet reflects the Chinese Communists' worldview, perception of order, and values, accords with the common aspiration of people in all countries, and points the direction for the progress of world civilisations. It is also the noble goal pursued by China in conducting major-country diplomacy with Chinese characteristics for the new era. CPC is not only dedicated to pursuing happiness for the Chinese people and rejuvenation for the Chinese nation, but also dedicated to human progress and world harmony.

Building a community with a shared future for mankind reflects the high degree of unity between CPC's original mission and the trend of the times, and embodies the greatest common divisor that people of all countries hope for a better world. It has significant theoretical value and profound historical significance, and increasingly demonstrates strong influence, vitality, and appeal. Since the dawn of this new era, building a community with a shared future for mankind has developed from a Chinese initiative to an international consensus, from a promising vision to substantive actions, and from a conceptual proposition to a scientific system. It has served as a glorious banner leading the progress of the times.

> China seeks to bring countries together to meet challenges and achieve prosperity for all, and usher in a bright future of peace, security, prosperity and progress for the world.

From bilateral to multilateral, from regional to global, China has built various forms of community with a shared future with dozens of countries and regions in various areas such as health, nature, internet, and ocean, playing a constructive role in promoting regional peace and development and making unique contribution to solving global problems. The Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) is a vivid example of building a global community of shared future, and a global public good and cooperation platform provided by China to the world.

Since introducing the BRI ten years ago, based on extensive consultation and joint contribution for shared benefits, China has pursued open, green, clean, and high-standard cooperation to promote sustainable development and improve people's lives, and advanced high-quality Belt and Road cooperation. It has laid the groundwork and set up the frameworks of BRI cooperation, delivering tangible results and achieving sustainable progress. Together, participants in the initiative have jointly advanced "hard connectivity", "soft connectivity" and "people-to-people connectivity", setting up an important platform that has enabled wide participation, built international consensus and pooled the strengths of all parties.

The Global Development Initiative, Global Security Initiative, and Global Civilisation Initiative proposed by China guide the advance of human society across these three dimensions. Resonating and complementing each other, they have evolved into a crucial cornerstone for building a global community of shared future, offering China's solutions to major challenges pertaining to peace and development for humanity. The international community has spoken highly of these three global initiatives, acknowledging that they reflect China's global vision and growing international influence and provide comprehensive solutions to the challenges confronting humanity.

Good principles

All good principles should adapt to changing times in order to remain relevant. A broad consensus of solidarity and cooperation has developed in the international community behind the proposal and the implementation of the concept of a global community of shared future to address the challenges facing humanity. Looking to the future, it is bound to shine as a pioneering thought with the power of truth that transcends time and space, opening up a beautiful prospect of common development, long-term stability, and sustained prosperity for human society.

When all countries unite in pursuing the cause of common good, plan together, and act together day by day towards the right direction of building a global community of shared future, we can build an open, inclusive, clean, and beautiful world of lasting peace, universal security and shared prosperity, and jointly create a better future for all of humanity.

(The author is China's Ambassador to Nepal.)

Menstrual Hygiene Boosts Women's Health

Dr. Shyam P Lohani



Menstruation is a natural and essential part of a woman's life, yet it remains a topic shrouded in secrecy and stigma. Good menstrual hygiene practices include changing sanitary pads or tampons regularly, washing the genital area with clean water and soap, and using clean and hygienic toilets. Poor menstrual hygiene can lead to various health problems, including urinary tract infections, bacterial vaginosis, and even cervical cancer. Therefore, it is crucial to educate women and girls about the importance of maintaining good menstrual hygiene practices. By tackling the taboo surrounding these topics openly and honestly, we can empower young individuals to make informed decisions about their sexual health while debunking harmful myths and stereotypes.

A cornerstone of reproductive health and maintaining proper menstrual hygiene is crucial for every woman, regardless of her age or sexual activity. Educating teenagers about the importance of using sanitary products, changing them regularly, and practicing good hygiene can prevent infections and other health complications. By promoting menstrual hygiene, we ensure that young women can navigate their menstrual cycles with confidence and comfort. It is also important to educate girls and women about menstrual hygiene, dispel myths and taboos surrounding menstruation, and provide access to affordable and safe sanitary products. Bear in mind, that menstrual hygiene practices may vary based on cultural, social, and personal preferences. Therefore, it is essential to find what works best for you and prioritise your comfort and well-being during menstruation.

Holistic approach

Maintaining personal hygiene during menstruation is crucial. Menstruation is often overlooked in comprehensive sexual education programmes, which is a disservice to young people. By incorporating menstrual health into sexual education, we can foster a more inclusive and holistic approach to reproductive health. Teaching teenagers about menstruation, and its biological functions and debunking myths can help normalize the topic and reduce the stigma surrounding it.

Understanding menstruation is crucial for young women to take control of their sexual health. By educating them about their menstrual cycles, they can better track their fertility, make informed decisions about contraception, and understand the importance of consent. Moreover, knowledge of menstrual health empowers young women to engage in healthy and consensual sexual relationships, promoting their overall well-being. At the same time, it is imperative to impart knowledge on disposing of sanitary products properly in designated bins or wrapped and placed in trash cans. Therefore, avoid flushing them down the toilet, as it can cause plumbing issues.

Many cultures perpetuate harmful taboos surrounding menstruation, often associating it with impurity or shame. By challenging these taboos, we can promote sexual liberation and gender equality. Normalizing menstruation encourages open conversations about sexual health, dismantling the barriers that prevent young individuals from seeking help, support, and information. Teenagers who engage in sexual activity need comprehensive support that includes addressing menstrual health. Providing access to affordable and safe sanitary products, promoting open dialogue about menstruation, and offering guidance on maintaining hygiene during sexual encounters are essential. Thus, imparting knowledge on these aspects helps ensure that young individuals can make informed decisions about their sexual health while prioritising their overall well-being.

> By educating them about their menstrual cycles, they can better track their fertility, make informed decisions about contraception, and understand the importance of consent.

Menstruation and sexual activities are two separate aspects of a person's life, but they can intersect in various ways. It is important to prioritise menstrual hygiene and sexual health to ensure overall well-being. It is time to break the silence surrounding menstruation and create an open dialogue about it. By openly discussing menstruation, we can educate both girls and boys about the natural process and eliminate the shame associated with it. This will not only help girls feel more comfortable and confident during their periods but also foster a supportive environment for them to seek help and advice.

In addition to menstrual hygiene, it is also essential to practice safe sex to prevent sexually transmitted infections (STIs) and unwanted pregnancies. Using condoms during sexual intercourse can help prevent the transmission of STIs and reduce the risk of unintended pregnancies. When it comes to sexual activities, it is essential to prioritise consent, communication, and safe practices.

Respecting boundaries

Menstruation should not be a barrier to engaging in consensual sexual activities if both partners are comfortable with it. However, it is important to note that some individuals may experience discomfort or pain during menstruation, and it is crucial to respect their boundaries and preferences. Menstruation and teenage sex are two separate topics, but they are interconnected. A lack of knowledge about menstrual hygiene can lead to girls feeling unprepared and anxious about engaging in sexual activities during their periods. This can result in them avoiding sexual encounters altogether or engaging in risky behaviours due to misinformation.

It is also important to be aware that engaging in sexual activities during menstruation may increase the risk of certain infections. The presence of blood can create a favourable environment for bacteria to grow. Therefore, using barrier methods, such as condoms, can help reduce the risk of sexually transmitted infections (STIs) and maintain good sexual health. Last but not least, menstruation and sexual activities are personal and individual experiences. Individuals need to prioritise their own comfort, hygiene, and sexual health while respecting the boundaries and preferences of their partners. Open communication, consent, and practicing safe sex are key elements in maintaining a healthy and fulfilling sexual life.

(Dr. Lohani is the executive director at Health Concern. lohanis@gmail.com.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 14, 1974

31 Receive Panchayat Training

Surkhet, Jan. 13: Thirty one persons received training at the regional panchayat training concluded the other day, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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READER'S MAIL

P.N. Shah Deserves Respect



The news your daily published under the heading *"Nepali Army marching to mark National Unity Day"* on Jan.13 lifted my spirits. To mark the birth anniversary of late King Prithvi Narayan Shah, also known as National Unity Day, Nepali Army (NA), organised a walk from Dharan to Dhankuta on Friday.

This is a modicum of respect the great king deserves for his immense contributions which continue to shape our psyche and national policies to this day. It's a well-documented fact that the unification campaign he led resulted in a well-fortified country capable enough to defend against invasion and unwanted foreign influence.

The groundwork he laid turned out to be the robust armour for his successors to keep invading imperialist forces at bay, which is why were never colonised. Today Nepal is one of the oldest countries in the world, and we, its proud inhabitants, owe much of our deep sense of pride to the revered king. There mustn't be an iota of reluctance when it comes to showing our deepest respect to the beloved king.

Kapil Basyal
Texas, USA

TAILPIECE

A wealthy merchant of 84 married a 25 year old fashion model. They had a wonderful honeymoon in Aruba but, unfortunately, the old boy suffered a coronary and was hospitalized.

When his young wife came to see him, the old man said, "Sweetheart, your future has been taken care of regardless of what happens to me. You will have an income of $250,000 a year, my home in Palm Springs, my ranch in Texas, my Mercedes. You'll never need to worry about money."

"Oh, sweetheart, please don't talk that way," his young wife exclaimed. "You've been so good to me already. If you go, I'll be devastated. Oh, there must be something I can do to help you. Please, tell me what I can do?"

"Well," the old man gasped, "you can quit pinching the inlet tube to my oxygen supply for starters."

Winter storm to bring life threatening chill to US

AP
ST. Louis, Jan. 13

Brutally cold weather could prove a deadly challenge Saturday amid a continuing wave of Arctic storms that has hammered much of the country with blinding snow, freezing rain and whipping winds.

Governors from New York to Louisiana declared states of emergency ahead of predicted snow and bone-chilling temperatures. In St. Louis, the National Weather Service bureau warned of rare and "life-threatening" cold.

The fierce weather blitzed campaign schedules in Iowa, the leadoff GOP caucus state. With a blizzard warning covering most of the state, Nikki Haley, Ron DeSantis and former President Donald Trump all shuffled their schedules ahead of Monday's presidential vote.

Near-record cold in Kansas City will make for a frigid NFL playoff game Saturday night, when the Chiefs host Miami. Fans will be allowed to bring in blankets and first-aid stations were set up at Arrowhead Stadium. On Sunday, fans in Buffalo will contend with up to a foot (30 centimetres) of snow and fierce winds as the Bills host Pittsburgh.



PHOTO: AP

Graphic designer Emily Brewer shovels out her driveway in order to drive to work in Sioux City, Iowa, early on Friday, Jan. 12, 2024.

The National Weather Service on Friday warned that a powerful storm would rock the Midwest to the Great Lakes through Saturday with heavy snow, strong winds and blizzards. Dangerously frigid weather would follow across the Rockies and the Plains, while heavy rain across the Northeast and Mid-Atlantic would threaten river and coastal flooding.

Some areas of the Northeast had flooding concerns. Emergency responders helped evacuate some residents from their homes in Paterson, New Jersey, early Friday as the Passaic River started overflowing its banks. The new storm, combined with one earlier in the week, created flooding worries in Maine and New Hampshire, too.

It was minus 11 degrees Fahrenheit (minus 24 Celsius) in Bismarck, North Dakota on Friday morning, and forecasters warned the weekend could see temperatures reach 20 below F (minus 29 C) by early Sunday.

Black ice from freezing rain caused wrecks and brought Kansas City, Missouri, to a standstill.

At the Double Cross Cattle Company, a ranch south of Roberts, Montana, Tyson Ropp used an axe on Friday morning to chop through inches of ice covering a trough so that his bulls could get to their water.

"It's just Montana," he added with a shrug.

But the weather won't spare any part of the country this weekend, forecasters said.

In the county that includes Portland, Oregon, which is more used to wintery rain than ice and snow, officials declared a weather emergency and opened severe weather shelters for the homeless. The county and non-profit groups this week distributed thousands of jackets, gloves, ponchos and other items.

In California, a warning of high avalanche danger was issued for parts of the Sierra Nevada, including the Lake Tahoe area, where an avalanche at a ski resort killed one man on Wednesday. The same was true in Idaho, where a man was presumed dead in an avalanche Thursday.

"EVERY state in the US has an active NWS watch, warning, or advisory," the National Weather Service announced Friday as it posted a color-coded map that showed portions of states under threat from storms, winds, floods, blizzards and avalanches.

Turkey launches airstrikes against Kurdish militants

AP
Istanbul, Jan. 13

Turkey carried out airstrikes targeting Kurdish militants in neighbouring Iraq and Syria on Saturday, the Turkish Defense Ministry said. This comes a day after an attack on a Turkish military base in Iraq killed nine Turkish soldiers.

Turkey often launches strikes against targets in Syria and Iraq it believes to be affiliated with the Kurdistan Workers' Party, or PKK, a banned Kurdish separatist group that has waged insurgency against Turkey since the 1980s.

The defense ministry said aircraft struck targets in Metina, Hakurk, Gara and Qandil in north Iraq, but didn't specify areas in Syria. It said fighter jets destroyed caves, bunkers, shelters and oil facilities "to eliminate terrorist attacks against our people and security forces ... and to ensure our border security." The statement added "many" militants were "neutralized" in the strikes.

On Friday night, attackers attempted to infiltrate a military base in northern Iraq's semi-autonomous Kurdish region, killing five soldiers. Four others died later of critical injuries. The Turkish Defense Ministry said 15 militants were also killed.

There was no immediate comment from the PKK, the government in Baghdad or the Kurdish region's administration.

Turkey launched Operation Claw-Lock in northern Iraq in April 2022, during which it established several bases in Duhok Governorate. Baghdad has repeatedly protested the presence of Turkish troops and called for their withdrawal.

Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan expressed his condolences for the deaths of the Turkish soldiers on social media platform X, formerly Twitter.

"We will fight to the end against the PKK terrorist organization within and outside our borders," he wrote.

President Recep Tayyip Erdogan was to hold a security meeting in Istanbul later Saturday, Fahrettin Altun, the president's communications director, wrote on X.

Meanwhile, Interior Minister Ali Yerlikaya announced police had detained 113 people suspected of ties to the PKK following raids across 32 Turkish provinces.

He added that four people were arrested after police identified 60 social media accounts that "praised the separatist terrorist organization for provocative purposes" or had spread misleading information.

Three weeks ago, PKK-affiliated militants tried to break into a Turkish base in northern Iraq, according to Turkish officials, leaving six soldiers dead. The following day, six more Turkish soldiers were killed in clashes.

US military strikes another Houthi-controlled site

AP
Washington, Jan. 13

The U.S. military early Saturday struck another Houthi-controlled site in Yemen that it had determined was putting commercial vessels in the Red Sea at risk, a day after the U.S. and Britain launched multiple airstrikes targeting Houthi rebels.

Associated Press journalists in Sanaa, Yemen's capital, heard one loud explosion.

U.S. Central Command said the "follow-on action" early Saturday local time against a Houthi radar site was conducted by the Navy destroyer USS Carney using Tomahawk land attack missiles.

The first day of strikes Friday hit 28 locations and struck more than 60 targets. President Joe Biden had warned Friday that the Houthis could face further strikes.

The latest strike came after the U.S. Navy on Friday warned American-flagged vessels to steer clear of areas around Yemen in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden for the next 72 hours after the initial airstrikes. The warning came as Yemen's Houthis vowed fierce retaliation, further raising the prospect of a wider conflict in a region already beset by Israel's war in Gaza.

U.S. military and White House officials said they expected the Houthis to try to strike back.

The U.S.-led bombardment — launched in response to a recent campaign of drone and missile attacks on commercial ships in the vital Red Sea — killed at least five people and wounded six, the Houthis said. The U.S. said the strikes, in two waves, took aim at targets in 28 different locations across Houthi-controlled areas of Yemen.

"We will make sure that we respond to the Houthis if they continue this outrageous behavior along with our allies," Biden told reporters during a stop in Emmaus, Pennsylvania.

Asked if he believes the Houthis are a terrorist group, Biden responded, "I think they are." The president in a later exchange with reporters during a stop in Allentown, Pennsylvania, said whether the Houthis are redesignated as such was "irrelevant."

Biden also pushed back against some lawmakers, both Democrats and Republicans, who said he should have sought congressional authorization before carrying out the strikes.

"They're wrong, and I sent up this morning when the strikes occurred exactly what happened," Biden said.

The Pentagon said Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin ordered the military action from the hospital where he is recovering from complications following prostate cancer surgery.

The White House said in November that it was considering redesignating the Houthis as a terrorist organization after they began their targeting of civilian vessels. The administration formally delisted the Houthis as a "foreign terrorist organization" and "specially designated global terrorists" in 2021, undoing a move by President Donald Trump



PHOTO: AP

Worshippers chant slogans after conclusion of Friday prayer to show their support of Palestinians and condemning the U.S. and British militaries strike against Iranian-backed Houthis in Yemen, in Tehran, Iran, Friday, Jan. 12, 2024.

Lt. Gen. Douglas Sims, director of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, said Friday's U.S. strikes were largely in low-populated areas, and the number of those killed would not be high. He said the strikes hit weapons, radar and targeting sites, including in remote mountain areas.

As the bombing lit the predawn sky over multiple sites held by the Iranian-backed rebels, it forced the world to again focus on Yemen's yearslong war, which began when the Houthis seized the country's capital.

Since November, the rebels have repeatedly targeted ships in the Red Sea, saying they were avenging Israel's offensive in Gaza against Hamas. But they have frequently targeted vessels with tenuous or no clear links to Israel, imperiling shipping in a key route for global trade and energy shipments.

PRISM

Lion cub sneaks up on sleeping dad

Sabi Sand Game Reserve: Ebenezer Rhode, a guide at the Sabi Sand Game Reserve, captured this adorable sighting on camera and shared the story with LatestSightings.com.

Rhode set out with his guests in search of the resident lion pride. Unfortunately, with all the rain the bush is very dense and they were not able to see the entire pride. However, the dominant male of the pride was luckily sleeping right next to the road, so he was easily visible. The guests were super excited to see the male lion, but he was fast asleep.

One of the cubs, a little ball of fur with big, curious eyes, decided it was playtime. This tiny cub started a stalk and began to sneak up on dad.

The cub was like a little predator in hunt mode! It used the lush greenery and thick bushes as cover. Every step was careful, and every move was calculated. The cub was so focused and determined to reach its dad without making a single sound. And it worked.

British Columbia ferries for sale

Egypt: A trio of ferries built for use in British Columbia in the late 1990s are for sale on Facebook Marketplace.

The Pacficat Explorer, Discovery and Voyager, known as the Fast Cats, were built for use by B.C. Ferries in the 1990s, but the catamarans were famously over-budget and failed to meet expectations for speed or efficiency.

Only two of the ferries were ever used by B.C. Ferries, the Explorer and Discovery, but they were pulled after just a few years of service and sold in 2003.

The ferries are now owned by the government of Egypt, which left the boats vacant when they were found to be unsuitable for use in the Red Sea.

Rob Arthurs, an international trade consultant based in British Columbia, said an Egyptian company was contracted to scrap the three boats, but they determined the vessels were still in good shape and could potentially be sold intact.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1236 – King Henry III of England marries Eleanor of Provence.
1639 – The "Fundamental Orders", the first written constitution that created a government, is adopted in Connecticut.
1761 – The Third Battle of Panipat is fought in India between the Afghans under Ahmad Shah Durrani and the Marathas.[4]
1900 – Giacomo Puccini's Tosca opens in Rome.
1907 – An earthquake in Kingston, Jamaica kills more than 1,000 people.
1952 – NBC's long-running morning news program Today debuts, with host Dave Garroway.[17]
1954 – The Hudson Motor Car Company merges with Nash-Kelvinator Corporation forming the American Motors Corporation.
1967 – Counterculture of the 1960s: The Human Be-In takes place in San Francisco, California's Golden Gate Park, launching the Summer of Love.

Nigerian group provides prosthetic limbs to amputee children

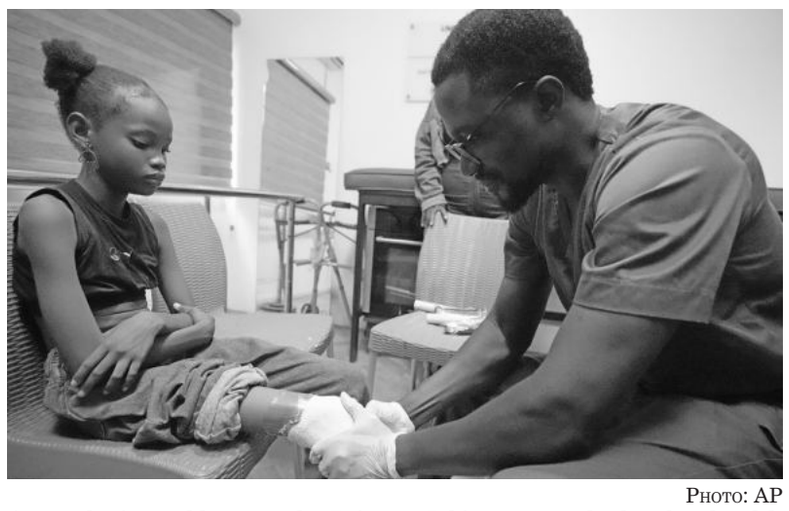


PHOTO: AP

A prosthetist molds a cast for Princess Igbinosa, 10, who lost her leg following a traffic accident in Lagos, Nigeria, Thursday, Nov. 30, 2023.

AP
Lagos, Nigeria, Jan. 13

The accident that broke 10-year-old Princess Igbinosa's right leg could have crushed her dreams of becoming a model in a country where not many can afford prosthetics to cope with life and fight social stigma.

"It was heartbreaking when they told us they had to amputate it (the leg)," her mother, Esther Igbinosa, said of Princess's experience in 2020. "During the first few months of her amputation ... I just wake up and start crying. I was like, how is she going to cope with life with an amputated leg?"

But Princess can now walk and her dreams are alive again, thanks to an artificial leg that matches the tone of her skin. The prosthesis came from the IREDE Foundation, a Nigerian group that provides children like her with free artificial limbs that normally cost $2,000 to $3,000.

"My dream is to become a model," Princess said. "When the accident happened, I thought I couldn't become a model. But now that I have two legs, I can become whatever I want — model, doctor, whatever."

Founded in 2012 in Nigeria's economic hub of Lagos, IREDE has provided more than 500 artificial limbs at no cost in addition to psychosocial support to children like Princess, said its executive director, Crystal Chigbu. She said the group gets up to 70% of its funding from crowdsourcing.

AI tools donated to help find missing children

AP
New York, Jan. 13

John Walsh, advocate for missing children and longtime host of "America's Most Wanted," said he feels outmanned by criminals all the time – especially in the courtroom.

"I say to myself, 'My god, the lawyer for this dirtbag predator is smarter and more sophisticated than the cops are'," the co-founder of the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children told The Associated Press. "They don't really know the technology."

Human traffickers and sexual predators often use high-end technology and increasingly take advantage of encryption to protect the details of their crimes, Walsh said. And even if they didn't, law enforcement officials, especially in smaller cities and towns, lack the budget and the access to the technological tools that would speed up the investigation and aid in the prosecution of the offenders.

Cellebrite DI, Ltd., wants to change that. The provider of digital tools that help law enforcement and private firms find and follow investigative leads on Friday launched "Operation Find Them All" – an initiative where the firm will donate its technology to nonprofits that help find endangered children, including the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children, the nonprofit The Exodus Road, which fights human trafficking around the world. The NASDAQ-traded company — which reported revenue of $85 million for the third quarter of 2023, up 17% year over year — will also make a financial donation to those organizations, as well as Raven, a political nonprofit that raises awareness of the threat of child exploitation online.



PHOTO: AP

Cellebrite Co-Founder Yossi Carmil and The Exodus Road Co-Founder Matt Parker meeting in Greece recently.

Yossi Carmil, Cellebrite's CEO, said the FBI had nearly 360,000 cases of missing children in 2022, while the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children received more than 32 million reports of suspected child sexual exploitation that year. Knowing that his company had the technology that could help children in trouble, Carmil said he felt Cellebrite had to do what it could.

"We are the biggest admirers of law enforcement," Carmil said. "However, they are understaffed, underequipped, and, at any point of time, regardless of how much the government will give them, they are under constraints. They always need to do more with less."

Kent Nielsen, digital forensic investigator for the Brazoria County Sheriff's Office in Texas, said his department currently uses Cellebrite technology to process data gathered from cell phones as well as its AI-driven software to analyze the data to find potential leads.

"The system really helps us with doing our jobs faster," said Nielsen, adding that one smartphone could contain more than 250,000 images to process. Rather than having an investigator look through those images and sort them, Cellebrite's Pathfinder software can handle it, while also linking them to locations, as well as other data from other smartphones or other cases.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Foreign tourists visiting Patan Durbar Square in Lalitpur on Saturday.

Maoist Centre's statute convention slated for February 13-15

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

The ruling CPN (Maoist Centre) has decided to organise its statute convention from February 13-15.

A meeting of the party's standing committee held at the party headquarters in Parisdanda today decided to hold the statute convention, CPN (Maoist Centre) Vice Chairman and Spokesperson Agni Prasad Sapkota confirmed.

According to Sapkota, the meeting also fixed the basis for the selection of the convention representatives.

Today's meeting also discussed the issues of unification bids with the like-minded political forces.

Sapkota stated that a unity coordination committee under the coordination of Chairman of CPN (Maoist Centre) Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has been formed.

During the meeting, party chairman and Prime Minister Prachanda briefed the standing committee members about the country's overall situation.

Likewise, all 10 in-charges of the party's province committees also shared the recently concluded 4-month-long campaign of the CPN (Maoist Centre).

Om Devi Malla elected president of National Cooperative Federation

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

Om Devi Malla is unanimously elected as the President of the National Cooperative Federation (NCF).

The 31st Annual General Meeting of the NCF held on 12 and 13 January in Kathmandu elected her to the post, making her the first female president of the organisation since its establishment three decades ago.

Malla was previously a Senior Vice-President of the NCF and also has been a global board member of the International Cooperative Federation and a member of the Constituent Assembly of Nepal.

She expressed her commitment to move ahead in cooperation with all to strengthen the cooperative campaign. She has succeeded Minraj Kandel, Keshav Badal and Deepak Prakash Baskota.

The AGM has elected 25 members to the Board of Directors and three members to the Audit Supervisory Committee unopposed.

Ramesh Prasad Pokharel is elected as the senior vice president. He is also the outgoing chairman of Rashtriya Sahakari Bank.

Khem Bahadur Pathak, D.B. Basnet and Indira Pant have been elected vice-presidents.

Similarly, Bhim Tulachan has been elected as the coordinator



of the Accounting Supervision Committee.

Other elected directors include Tek Prasad Chaulagai, Huma Kumari JC (Anju), Badri Prasad Lamsal, Kashi Chandra Baral, Paritosh Paudyal, Harihar Nath Yogi, Madhav Prasad Joshi, Shambhu Prasad, Chhatra Prasad Rimal, Parbati Neupane, Tika Neupane, Nathuni Yadav, Prem Prasad Subedi Jaisi, Suman Nepal, Homnath Jaisi, Ekata Shah, Yogmaya Subedi, Sharda Dahal, and Kamala Kumari Subedi Paudel.

Likewise, Amarnath Neupane and Hem Kumari Adhikari are the newly elected members of the Accounts Supervision Committee.

FIVE KILLED IN CHANDRAGIRI CAR ACCIDENT

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

The death toll of the Setopahara car accident occurred at Panighat of Chandragiri Municipality-4 this afternoon rises to five.

Smarika Gautam, who was receiving treatment at Vayodha Hospital, died, according to according to Superintendent of Police, Kumodh Dhungel.

Other killed in the accident include Omkar Nidhi Tiwari, 76, and Kalpana Tiwari, 64, from Maitidevi and Dr Mahesh Kumar Gautam and four-year-old Priyansh Gautam from Lazimpat, Kathmandu. All four died on the spot.

The vehicle (Pra3-01-23 Cha 6985) heading to Chitlang from Kathmandu fell some 500 meters off the road after it lost control. Injured one in the accident Dr Sristi Tiwari, mother of six-year-old Smarika, is receiving treatment at Vayodha Hospital. The mishap occurred at 1:55 this afternoon.

Kathmandu to get Melamchi water from tomorrow

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

Minister for Drinking Water Mahindra Raya Yadav has said that water from Melamchi drinking water project would be distributed in the Kathmandu Valley from January 15.

"Water from Melamchi has arrived at Sundarijal. Water distribution in Kathmandu will begin at 9:00 am on January 15," Minister Yadav said on Saturday during an inspection visit to the Sundarijal-based Water Treatment Plant.

He claimed that the water from Sundarijal will be supplied in all seasons in Kathmandu adding that the water was brought to Sundarijal prior to the deadline.

On the occasion, Minister Yadav directed the agencies and officials to fix broken pipeline and drinking water meter in different parts of the city.

Water is being channeled to Kathmandu again after repair and maintenance of the project which was damaged after flood and landslides in the project site in Sindhupalchowk district.



PHOTO: RSS

A reservoir in Sundarijal is being filled with water from Melamchi shows preparations for sending Melamchi water to Kathmandu.

Secretary at the Ministry of Drinking Water Suresh Acharya said that water supply would be ensured in Anamnagar, Minbhawan, Mahakalchaur, Rigani, Bhaktapur, Khumaltar, Balaju and Bansbari areas on January 15. It will be gradually distributed in other parts of the city, he added.

Preparations are underway to distribute Melamchi water to the folks in the city and around 170 million litres of water is supplied to Kathmandu every day.

Challenges of fine tuning...

But what is true is that we are not seeing much improvement in this seasonal outlook as well."

The seasonal outlook was prepared twice a year at the initial time in 2020, but this past October, we endeavoured to create forecasts for three seasons. The accuracy of the seasonal outlook remains low due to a lack of technology, limited knowledge, and insufficient human resources dedicated to the seasonal forecasting process, Humagain added.

He mentioned that the winter season comprises only three to four per cent of the total annual rainfall, and this percentage could be met with three to four precipitation events even in late February. "We are not in a position to declare our system a total failure, because we still have time," he added.

Rajendra Man Shrestha, a senior meteorologist retired from DHM, stated that according to various global models from different countries, Nepal, along with other South Asian countries, is expected to remain dry this winter season, except for Odisha. "Central Nepal has exhibited a deficiency, and other parts of the country also indicate lower rainfall for this season." However, he is unaware of the DHM forecast outlook for this season.

To achieve normal rainfall, there should be at least two rainfall events in December and four events in January. However, both the months have remained dry so far. Although there will be very minimal precipitation on coming Tuesday and Wednesday, it is not sufficient to have normal rainfall, Shrestha informed.

"To attain above-normal rainfall for the remaining period, there needs to be heavy precipitation in a single or two days, otherwise, meeting the above-normal rainfall prediction would be challenging. However, upon observing the global model, there is no indication of such rainfall for Nepal this time, as there should be a deep impact of the western disturbance," he added.

Ujjwal Upadhyay, a climate analyst and climate change expert, however, asserted that the DHM seasonal outlook is a complete failure. "The seasonal forecast failed in the current monsoon, both the temperature rise and rainfall predictions were inaccurate. The winter outlook for this season is also a complete failure as the country has not received any rainfall so far," he said.

There is a chance of slight rainfall in Kathmandu this Tuesday and Wednesday, while high altitudes are expected to receive precipitation on Monday due to a western disturbance. The country's mid-hill line from Pokhara to Ilam will experience rainfall from Monday to Wednesday as the depression line enters the country on Sunday and persists until Friday, Upadhyay added.

Impact on agriculture

Nepal is in crisis due to minimal winter rainfall in recent years, impacting agriculture and livelihoods. In 2023, the situation worsened, with only 7.9 mm of winter rainfall recorded. Normally, Nepal receives an average of 60.1 mm (3 to 4% of the total rainfall of the year), and Kathmandu gets around 100 mm during the winter. This deficit poses serious challenges for food production and security, Pokharel added.

Winter wheat, mustard, lentils, barley, and vegetable crops are experiencing adverse effects due to the absence of winter rains over the past few years. The lack of snowfall this year is anticipated to affect apple and corn crops at higher elevations, and it may also impact the availability of springs across the entire Himalayan foothills.

Upadhyay said that there was not enough rainfall even during the summer season last year as well, so it will impact the entire system of the country, including food security, water sources, and livelihoods.

Although the short-term forecast was somehow accurate, the information dissemination was inadequate, leading farmers in Tarai to incur losses worth billions of rupees as their harvested paddy got damaged in the fields in 2021."

Quoting farmers in Tarai, Upadhyay mentioned, "Farmers in Tarai have not planted their paddy on Asar 15 (paddy plantation day in Nepal) for the last 15 years, and this is, of course, impacting the food supply system of the country."

New Nepal-made tractors...

The millet cleaning machine was also launched at the expo organised by the Nepal Agricultural Machinery Entrepreneurs Association (NAMEA) in Pokhara.

According to the experts, Nepal imports more than 95 per cent of agricultural machines from India, China and other countries. President of NAMEA, Krishna Sharma said that the market of agricultural equipment in Nepal is worth about Rs. 24 billion and the country is spending hard-earned foreign currency to buy the machines. But often farmers here don't get the machines that fit the needs of Nepali farms and geography.

Shrestha said that the government's policy is yet to be made favourable for the domestic industries. "There is more than 50 per cent value addition in the agricultural machinery produced in Nepal. Chandragiri Tractors have also 40-50 per cent value addition but we have to pay up to 40 per cent customs duties for the items like tyres and motors which are used in the machines," he said.

He stated that the industries should be allowed to import such goods as raw materials which will significantly reduce their customs duty. Similarly, the industries have to pay 13 per cent Value Added Tax (VAT) on iron as well which contributes to the increased price of the product.

According to Shrestha, if the government waives the VAT on raw materials and reduces the customs duty and other taxes, the price of Chandragiri tractors could go down by as much as 40 per cent.

More than 30 Palestinians killed in Israeli Gaza strikes

AP
Rafah, Jan. 13

More than 30 Palestinians, including young children, were killed in Israeli bombardments overnight into Saturday in the Gaza Strip, officials said, while a new U.S. strike against Iran-backed rebels in Yemen heightened fears that the Israel-Hamas war could escalate into a regional conflict.

Fears of a wider conflagration have been palpable since the start of the war, triggered by the deadly Oct. 7 attack on southern Israel by Hamas and other Gaza militants.

New fronts quickly opened, with Iran-backed groups — Houthi rebels in Yemen, Hezbollah in Lebanon and Iran-backed militias in Iraq and Syria — carrying out a range of attacks. From the start, the U.S. increased its military presence in the region to deter an escalation.

Following a Houthi campaign of drone and missile attacks on commercial ships in the Red Sea, the U.S. and Britain launched multiple airstrikes against the rebels Friday, and the U.S. hit another site Saturday.

In another fallout from the war, the International Court of Justice heard allegations by South Africa this week that Israel committed genocide against the Palestinians. The complaint cited the soaring death toll and hardships among Gaza civilians, along with inflammatory comments from Israeli leaders cited as proof of what South Africa said was genocidal intent.

In counter arguments Friday, Israel asked that the case be dismissed as meritless. Israel's defense argued that Israel had the right to fight back against an enemy bent on its destruction, that South Africa had barely mentioned Hamas and that it ignored what Israel considers attempts to mitigate civilian harm.



PHOTO: AP

Palestinians mourn relatives killed in the Israeli bombardment of the Gaza Strip in Rafah on Saturday.

The court was asked by South Africa to issue interim injunctions, including calling for a halt to Israel's offensive.

In Gaza, where Hamas has put up but stiff resistance to Israel's blistering air and ground campaign, the war continued unabated.

The Gaza Health Ministry said Saturday that 135 Palestinians were killed in the last 24 hours, bringing the overall toll of the war to 23,843. The count does not differentiate between combatants and civilians, but the ministry has said about two-thirds of the dead are women and children. The ministry said the total number of war-wounded surpassed 60,000.

Following an Israeli airstrike before dawn Saturday, video provided by Gaza's Civil Defense department showed rescue workers searching through the twisted rubble of a building in Gaza City by flashlight.

Footage showed them carrying a young girl wrapped in blankets with injuries to her face, and at least two other children who appeared dead. A boy, covered in dust, winced as he was loaded into an ambulance.

The attack on the home in the Daraj neighborhood killed at least 20 people, according to Civil Defense spokesperson Mahmoud Bassal.

Another strike late Friday near the southern city of Rafah on the Egyptian border killed at least 13 people, including two children. The bodies of those killed, primarily from a displaced family from central Gaza, were taken to the city's Abu Youssef al-Najjar hospital where they were seen by an Associated Press reporter.

Israel has argued Hamas is responsible for the high civilian casualties, saying its fighters make use of civilian buildings and launch attacks from densely populated urban areas.

The Israeli military released a video Saturday that it said showed the destruction of two ready-to-use rocket launching compounds in Al-Muharraqa in central Gaza.

Suryodaya: An Ode To Prem Acharya

BY MANNU SHAHI

Utsaha Joshi, better known by his stage name Uniq Poet, is a Nepali rapper presently based in Melbourne, Australia, who rose to prominence through the iconic Hip-Hop show 'Raw Barz.' Inspired by musicians like Eminem, J. Cole, Kendrick Lamar, Nas, Jay-Z, MGK and Tupac among others, Uniq ventured into writing and composing his own material from his teenage years.

With over two dozen singles, a full-length album "Kaalo" (2021), and numerous free verse poetry sessions published on his YouTube handle brimming with innovative, accessible and engrossing content, the emcee has also partaken in numerous collaborations, including the 2020 grandiose all-star alliance 'Kalamkranti Cypher – The Biggest Hiphop Collaboration Ever' presented by Halla, 'Wondergods' with Rohit Shakya x The Underdogs, 'Makassam' with Indian rapper Void and 'Jheli' featuring KaviG, while simultaneously working with numerous prominent figures such as Albatross, Sacar, Balen, Neetesh Jung Kuwar, Mc Flo, Robin Tamang to name a few.

And in the spirit of collaborations, on Friday, January 12, the emcee aligned his poignant lyrics with French film-maker Anna Deluche and poet Prakriti Bhattrai Basnet to create the astounding masterpiece 'Suryodaya'. Directed by Anna, this ethically driven piece is an ode to late Prem Acharya, and its video features actors JLson Adhikari and Surabhi Sapkotha. Similarly, Stellarstudios is credited with the video production and Realkpass with music production.



On January 24, 2023, Prem Acharya, an entrepreneur from Ilam, trying his best to support his family through his earnings and fed up with the degrading political state of the country decided to put everything on the line. In a horrendous turn of events, the civilian set himself on fire in front of the gate of the parliament building as a form of protest against the ruling political force. Acharya left behind 32 pages of notes detailing his struggles and the perceived lack of fairness prevalent in the country.

Learning of this tragic incident from the news, Anna, who has been in Nepal since 2018 working on a documentary about the living goddess Kumari, felt disturbed and unsettled as the images of the incident kept flashing in her memory. So, she decided to dedicate a tribute art-piece to this late patriot. And, while searching for the right voice for this project, Anna stumbled upon Uniq and his socio-politically inclined ventures like his 2020 single 'Mero Desh Birami'.

The filmmaker shared her vision with the emcee, hoping his expressions might justify the frustrations of the Nepali working class.

Anna explains, "We both visualised the symbol of fire as the nucleus to the project; the very fire that Prem Acharya used as a symbolic gesture to end his life, but also the fire that can be encountered everywhere around Nepal, especially Kathmandu. The fire of trash burning, fire of ritual ceremonies, fire is omnipresent in Nepal, in contrast to the west."

"We further decided that this theme of fire could mean several things: the destructive and scary fire that can take everything including our lives, but also the fire igniting deep within us fueling our will for existence."

Accordingly, the story arc of the video starts with the protagonist being triggered by the fire omitted from his lighter as it rejuvenates the memory of Prem Acharya and concludes with his realisation of the fire within him that can also fuel the inherent need for change.

The title 'Suryodaya,' penned by Uniq, was chosen to represent fire in the context of hope, as the dawn of a new day and a new beginning. Anna further explains her team's emphasis on developing this project ethically, with the full consent of Prem Acharya's family, and without any intention of exploiting his gesture for personal profit.

Furthermore, poet Bhattrai Basnet, who also contributes in the outro section, adds a further dimension to the already ingenious piece. The song feels like one of the rapper's best works in my opinion, a must-listen tune for its creative brilliance and empathetic social message.

Brunei's Prince Mateen weds fiancée in lavish ceremony



AP
Kuala Lumpur, Jan. 13

Brunei's Prince Abdul Mateen, one of Asia's most popular royal figures, has married his fiancée in an elaborate 10-day ceremony.

The 32-year-old prince, once dubbed one of Asia's most eligible bachelors, married Anisha Rosnah Isa-Kalebic, 29, in a ceremony that began on January 7 and will end on Tuesday. A solemnisation ceremony was held at a mosque on Thursday.

Mateen is the fourth son and 10th child of Sultan Hassanal Bolkiah, one of the world's richest men. While sixth in line to the throne, the prince has gained prominence in recent years accompanying his father on diplomatic engagements.

The sultan announced Mateen and Anisha's engagement in October. Anisha is the granddaughter of the ruler's special advisor. Mateen, who plays polo and is a helicopter pilot in the Royal Brunei Air Force, has a 2.5 million-strong following on Instagram. Anisha reportedly owns a fashion brand and tourism business.

Sunday's main wedding reception at the 1,788-room palace will see an array of international royalty and dignitaries, along with a parade through the capital, Bandar Sri Begawan.

The Emmy Awards: A guide to how to watch, who you'll see, and why it all has taken so long

BY ANDREW DALTON (AP)
Los Angeles, Jan. 13

The 2023 Emmy Awards are arriving in 2024. Hollywood's two strikes meant a four-month delay for television's annual celebration of itself. But both have now been resolved and the show will go on. Here's a look at the telecast, the ceremony, and the series and stars up for awards.

When are the Emmy awards and who will appear?

The 75th Primetime Emmy Awards will be held on the Martin Luther King Jr. holiday, Monday night at the Peacock Theatre in Los Angeles. Anthony Anderson will host. It will be telecast live on the Fox network starting at 8 pm Eastern, and available to stream the following day on Hulu.

Fox is taking its turn this year in an annual rotation between the four networks. Anderson, who was nominated for lead actor in a comedy seven times for his work on ABC's Black-ish' is a first-time Emmy host, although he's hosted the NAACP Image Awards eight times.

He also has a fresh connection to Fox — his new game show 'We Are Family' premiered in early January.

Now with a TV-themed name, downtown LA's Peacock Theatre, formerly the Microsoft Theatre and the Nokia Theatre, has been the go-to home for the Emmys since 2008.

Others appearing on the show stage as presenters and in other roles include Quinta Brunson and Pedro Pascal, who are both also nominees for multiple Emmys, along with Jodie Foster, Jenna Ortega, Jason Bateman, Stephen Colbert, Jon Hamm, Ken Jeong and Sheryl Lee Ralph.

Nominees and early winners

As is typical at the Emmys, HBO shows dominated the nominations when they were announced way back in July. The top three nominees — 'Succession' with 27, 'The Last of Us' with 24, and 'The White Lotus' with 23 — were all from the gilded cable channel.

'The Last of Us' comes in with a big head start on the grand total after winning eight at the Creative Arts Emmys, which are held about a week before the main ceremony. The dystopian video-game adaption won best guest actor and guest actress in a drama for memorable one-episode performances from Nick Offerman and Storm Reid. And it dominated in the technical categories, winning best visual effects and best prosthetic makeup for its fungus-faced walking dead.

'The White Lotus' took four trophies at the Creative Arts Emmys, winning for its music, its casting and its hairstyling.

'Succession' came up empty, but the fourth and final season of the show about a generationally dysfunctional family of one-percenters could still dominate in major categories on Monday. It's probably still the favourite for best drama, which it has won at two of the past three Emmys, and the acting categories are overloaded with its ensemble cast. Brian Cox, Jeremy Strong and Kieran Culkin are all up for best actor in a drama, four more men from the show are up for best supporting actor and Sarah Snook got a best actress nomination.



'The White Lotus' managed to get five nominees in the supporting actress category, including Jennifer Coolidge and Aubrey Plaza.

And if voters' affection continues for 'The Last of Us,' it could also win best drama; its stars Pascal and Bella Ramsey are nominated in the lead acting categories.

'The Bear,' nominated in comedy categories despite being heavy on drama, won four Emmys at the Creative Arts ceremonies and is nominated for 13 overall. 'Ted Lasso,' which won two, was tops among comedies with 21 overall nominations for its final season. The Emmys have loved the Apple TV+ soccer series since its kick-off. It won best comedy series and best actor for Jason Sudeikis in each of its first two seasons and is nominated to threepeat in both categories.

Celebrating 75 with big moments

This is the 75th time the Emmys are being handed out, and the Television Academy is celebrating by marking big TV moments from the past and trying to make a few of their own.

Members of the academy and academics collaborated to create a list of the 75 Most Impactful Television Moments that was revealed Friday. The list is topped by the moon landing and includes King's "I have a dream" speech, the Beatles' appearance on 'The Ed Sullivan Show' and famous scenes from 'Seinfeld,' 'The Sopranos' and 'Sesame Street.'

And during Monday night's show, producers will present a series of cast reunions and scene recreations from beloved shows including 'Cheers,' 'I Love Lucy,' 'Grey's Anatomy' and 'Martin.'

Why were the awards postponed?

Hollywood's historic work stoppage among writers and actors, both essential to the Emmys, meant the show had a rare delay for an unprecedented four months.

Leaders of the Television Academy were among those breathing a sigh of relief when actors voted to approve their new strike-ending contract on December 5, 2023 and put a period on the entire stoppage.

With an autumn show date based around the traditional broadcast TV season, the Emmys have for years had some quirks based on the far more scattered schedule of cable and streaming. The delay makes those oddities even odder.

To give one example, the nominations for 'The Bear' are for its first season, even though the awards will be handed out six months after its second season dropped.

In another anomaly, by the time of the ceremony, all the winners will have been established, the metaphorical envelopes sitting unopened for more than four months. That's because the Television Academy wanted at least the voting to be the same as always, so its approximately 20,000 members had to cast their ballots by August 28.

The January date puts the Emmys within the rest of Hollywood's awards season, a week after the Golden Globes and about six weeks before the Screen Actors Guild Awards — both ceremonies that honour television along with movies.

The delay is the first time the Emmys have been postponed since 2001, when the 9/11 attacks came just five days before the planned ceremony. That ceremony would end up being held in November.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: Inner clarity can be reached when your intuition is heightened. You may get a gut feeling during your day that leads you to pivot from your original plan of action.

CANCER: Friends might be attempting to help you out. It may be that you feel lost when it comes to your routine or organisation, or you could simply have too much going on for one person to sort out.

LIBRA: It could be hard to find support. While you may feel capable of standing tall and tackling your responsibilities, be wary -- if you need to reach out, you might not receive the desired aid.

CAPRICORN: Drama may lead to a change of plans. You could realise that someone is not able to fulfil their promises to you (or that they aren't willing to). The root issue is likely out of your control.

TAURUS: You're letting go of who you thought you were. There may be certain character traits or mindsets that you believed were a part of you, but you can currently realise that indulging these traits means self-sabotaging.

LEO: Your image may be updating. You might feel more capable of making changes to your outward appearance right now, whether this means an updated hairstyle, an unfamiliar outfit.

SCORPIO: Someone in your life might act in ways you weren't expecting. This can shake your foundation, because you may have made plans that depended on them acting in a predictable way.

AQUARIUS: Domestic change is on the wind. This could be related to the home itself -- you're possibly changing the decor, cleaning and reorganising, or even painting walls and repairing appliances.

GEMINI: You're creating stability. Whether you have children that you're making plans for, so that they can move forward in a great trajectory, or you have friends that you want to lend a hand to.

VIRGO: You might get rerouted at any moment. While you may have thought your course was set in a way that would be easy-breezy, roadblocks may pop up and force you to manoeuvre around them.

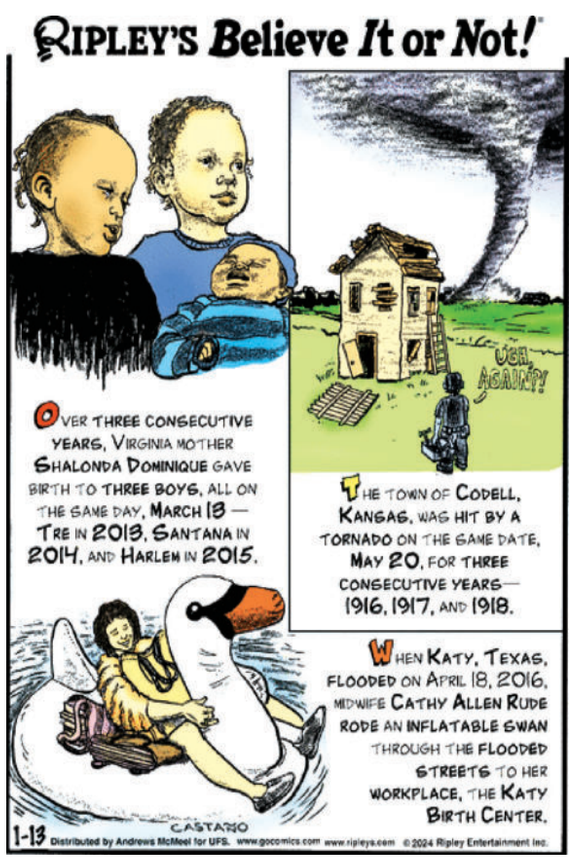
SAGITTARIUS: Your routine may not serve you the way it used to. While your habits might have worked for you in the past, circumstances in your life have likely changed.

PISCES: Authority figures might not immediately understand your current needs. You and they could come from different backgrounds or separate generations, and because of this.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal Police, Lumbini, Madhes start PM Cup Men's National Cricket with wins

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 13

Nepal Police, Madhes Province and Lumbini Province started their PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament 2024 campaign with wins as one of the biggest domestic cricket leagues kicked off in three venues – two in Kathmandu and one in Rupandehi – on Saturday.

Nepal Police defeated Bagmati Province by 68 runs at the TU International Cricket Ground thanks to Rashid Khan's century and two wickets. Rashid entered the pitch when Nepal Police was at 5-72 after electing to bat first. With Aarif, who got out at 40.5 overs after scoring 57 off 66 balls, Rashid took the team to 192. With nine fours and six sixes, Rashid remained not out at 106 (112 balls) with Sagar Dhakal as the 50 overs of the first inning came to an end with 282 runs on the board. Rijan Dhakal and Surya Tamang claimed three wickets each for Bagmati.

Sagar Dhakal was the highest wicket-taker for Police with three. Karan KC, Rashid Khan and captain Dipendra Singh Airee took two wickets each as the team bowled out Bagmati at 214 runs in 42.3 overs.

Bagmati was in with a chance as long as Ashutosh Ghiraiya was at the crease. Opening batsman Ghiraiya was caught by Dilip Nath at 37.2 overs in the bowl of Airee after falling only eight runs short of a century. Ghiraiya hit nine fours and four sixes to reach 92 runs in 87 balls.

Nepal Police proved its bowling line-up strong as it was the only team to elect to bat first. The morning weather was favourable for the fielding side, yet Police batted first and bowled when the pitch started favouring the batting side in the afternoon. Madhes and Lumbini had elected to bowl first after winning the toss in their respective matches.

In another opening match of the campaign at Mulpani International Cricket Ground, Madhes won against Koshi by seven wickets. Madhes had 179 balls to spare as they chased the target of 128 runs in the loss of only three wickets.

Electing to bowl first, Madhes' bowlers bowled out Koshi in 41 overs with only two batsmen scoring in two digits. Koshi's captain Ankit Subedi and vice-captain Firdosh Ansari scored 40 and 41 runs respectively. Pradip Paswan took three wickets while Rajesh Yadav, Ranjit Kumar and Pawan Sarraf claimed two each for Madhes.

Chasing a low target, the opening partnership of Madhes' captain Harishankar Sah and wicket-keeper-batsman Anil Sah was almost enough to begin the team's campaign with a win. Harishankar was caught in the bowl of Sujan Thapaliya at 12.1 overs and departed at 24 off 33. Madhes was at 83 in the loss of the first wicket.

Mayan Yadav tried playing a supportive inning as Anil was taking the helm; however, he was struck leg before by Sonu Mandal leaving Madhes at 103/2 in 15.2 overs. Meanwhile, unable to finish the match himself, Anil departed after being caught behind by Mandal in 17.3 overs. Anil hit 14 fours and three sixes to score 88 runs at a strike rate of 162.96.

Niraj Yadav scored a four in the first ball of Firdosh in the 21st over to take Madhes to 129 runs and win the match.

Likewise, in a game reduced to 42 overs each due to bad weather, Lumbini grabbed a win in front of its home crowd at Bhairahawa Cricket Ground defeating Gandaki by seven wickets. Gandaki had 82 balls to spare.

Lumbini's wicketkeeper-captain Sushant Thapa elected to bowl first and the decision proved correct as Gandaki was bowled out at 111 runs in 34.4 overs. Ajay Chauhan's five-wicket haul was one of the most impressive stats of the day. Chauhan only gave 16 runs in 8.4 overs with two maidens. Karan Pangeni's disciplined batting to score 28 runs off 62 balls was the highest score for Gandaki.

Lumbini started the chase of 112 runs decently as the first wicket fell off in the 11th over at 33 runs. Bipin Khatri took the first wicket for Gandaki and sent two more Lumbini batsmen back to the pavilion in his spell of nine overs. Kamal Pariyar took the remaining three wickets, but Lumbini's batsmen were able to reach the target at 28.2 overs.

Bagmati is playing its second match of the campaign on Sunday at the TU Cricket Ground against Nepal APF Club. While Karnali and Gandaki will face each other in Bhairahawa, there is no match at Mulpani on January 14.

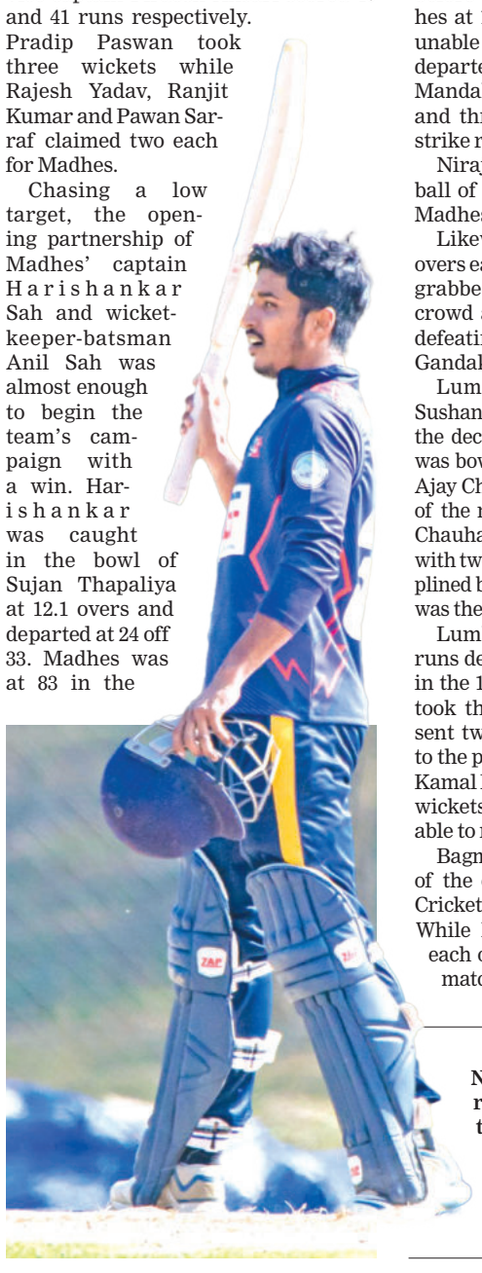


PHOTO: CAN
Nepal Police Club's Rashid Khan raises his bat after scoring a century in an opening match of PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament 2024 against Bagmati at TU International Cricket Ground on Saturday.

Haaland probably out until January end

AP
Manchester, Jan. 13

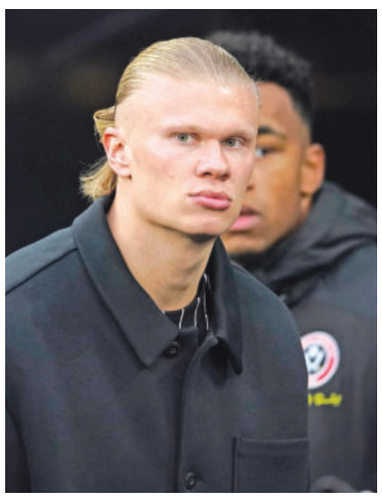
Erling Haaland was ruled out of Manchester City's Premier League game at Newcastle, his ninth straight miss, on Saturday because of a foot injury, and he is likely to be out until the end of January.

The Norway striker has missed the past eight games in all competitions though he's still the co-leading scorer in the league with 14 goals. Haaland hasn't played since a 1-0 loss to Aston Villa on Dec. 6.

"Hopefully at the end of this month he'll be ready," City manager Pep Guardiola said. "It was a little bit more than we expected in the beginning.

"It's the bone. It needs time. With every injury, you can do whatever you want but it's a question of time."

On Friday, Guardiola also confirmed that defender John Stones (ankle) won't suit up against Newcastle.



"Erling is out and John is out," the manager said. The 23-year-old Haaland, who has returned to training, has also scored five goals in Champions League play this campaign.

Playmaking midfielder Kevin De Bruyne is set for more minutes on Saturday, possibly as a starter for the defending champions as they look to pull within two points of league leader Liverpool.

The Belgium international returned from a hamstring injury Sunday as a second-half substitute in City's 5-0 win over Huddersfield in the FA Cup. Right on cue, De Bruyne provided an assist on Jeremy Doku's goal.

Guardiola said the midfielder looks "really good (and) dynamic" and indicated he's ready to start.

The team will head to Abu Dhabi after the match at St. James' Park for some warm-weather training ahead of its next game — at Tottenham on January 26 in the fourth round of the FA Cup.

India includes four spinners in squad for opening tests against England

AP
Mumbai, Jan. 13

India has included four spinners in its squad for the first two tests against England but experienced seamer Mohammed Shami is not yet fit to take part.

Axar Patel and Kuldeep Yadav did not travel to South Africa for the recent drawn test series against the Proteas but came back into contention on home pitches that are expected to take plenty of turn.

They join Ravichandran Ashwin and all-rounder Ravindra Jadeja in a 16-man party that will contest the opening games of the five-match series in Hyderabad and Visakhapatnam.

Ashwin needs just 10 more wickets to become the ninth bowler to take 500 career wickets in tests. The 95-test offspinner currently sits in second place in wickets taken for India behind Anil Kumble (619).



PHOTO: INDIAN CRICKET TEAM
Rohit Sharma is captaining the Test squad against England with Jasprit Bumrah as vice-captain.

When England last toured India in 2021, it crumbled in the face of extreme turn as Ashwin and Patel combined to take 60 wickets.

Uncapped wicketkeeper Dhruv Jurel was one of three glovemen named Friday by the Board of Control for Cricket in India, joining KL Rahul and KS Bharat, with Ishan Kishan still out after missing the recent South Africa tour for personal reasons.

Shami is currently recovering from an ankle problem and hopes to feature later in the five-match series, which begins in Hyderabad on Jan. 25, while fellow pace bowler Prasidh Krishna (quad) is also out.

Rohit Sharma continues to lead the side, assisted by vice-captain Jasprit Bumrah. Shubman Gill, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Virat Kohli, Shreyas Iyer, KL Rahul, KS Bharat, Dhruv Jurel, Ravichandran Ashwin, Ravindra Jadeja, Axar Patel, Kuldeep Yadav, Mohammed Siraj, Mukesh Kumar and Avesh Khan are the players in the squad.

SNIPPETS

Army's runners win top three spots in 3rd Rishing Open Ultramarathon

Tanahun (TRN): Three runners associated with Tribhuwan Army Club, claimed the top three positions at the 3rd Rishing Open Ultramarathon on Friday. The race was organised on National Unity Day and Prithvi Jayanti. Govinda Karki was the first to complete the 43-km-long race. Karki finished the race in 3 hours 6 minutes and 33 seconds defeating 32 other runners. Gopal Tamang and Tilak Sunuwar from Tribhuwan Army Club finished the race in second and third positions respectively. The race started from Bhanjyang, an entry point of Rishing, to Dubukot View Point passing through Ranipokhari, Puranthok, Arkhalchhap, Kafaldanda, Chalise (Purano Rishing), Pokharibhanjyang, Gothadi, Dhungade, Bhirkot, Archaldi, Mauribas and Dangsiri. The organisers awarded a purse of Rs. 65,000, Rs. 40,000 and Rs. 25,000 to the top three-positioned runners respectively.

First Ilam Gold Cup's fixtures made public

Ilam (TRN): Organisers have made public the fixtures for the first edition of the Ilam Gold Cup on Friday. Eight teams from different parts of the country and India are participating in the cup organised by Ilam's Red Horse Football Club. The teams, distributed in two groups, will play in a knockout format. In Group A, the organiser is facing Darjeeling's Manebhanjyang Football Club on the opening day on January 20, and Kathmandu's NRT will face Sarlahi's Bagmati Youth Club on January 22. In Group B, Itahari's Rastriya Jagriti Club and Jhapa's Birtamod United will face on January 21. Butwal United FC, a team that participated in the 2nd season of NSL, is facing Panchthar Football Club on January 23. Two winners from Groups A and B will play in the semi-finals on January 24 and 25 respectively. The final will take place on January 27. The winner will get Rs. 500,000 while the runner-up will receive Rs. 300,000 in cash.

Lehecka wins in Adelaide and Navarro in Hobart

Adelaide (AP): On Saturday the seventh-seeded Czech national Jiri Lehecka, 22, beat unseeded Briton Jack Draper 4-6, 6-5, 6-3 in the final of the Adelaide International to win his first ATP Tour level final. Lehecka beat third-seeded Sebastian Korda 6-3, 6-2 in the semifinals to reach his second tour final. Draper also was playing in his second final and his second in succession after losing to Adrian Mannarino in the final of the Sofia Open in November. Lehecka will play Bernabe Zapata Miralles of Spain in the first round of the Australian Open while Draper will play Marcos Giron of the United States. Likewise, Second-seeded American Emma Navarro, 22, claimed her first WTA Tour title in her first final Saturday when she beat two-time champion, top-seeded Elise Mertens 6-1, 4-6, 7-5 to win the Hobart International. Navarro outlasted Mertens of Belgium. Navarro is the 27th-seeded player at next week's major and will play Wang Xiyu of China in the first round in her Australian Open debut.

Djokovic says his wrist is OK, plans to start 2024 with an Aussie title

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 13

The injury update from Novak Djokovic was all good on the eve of his Australian Open title defence.

Djokovic hurt his wrist playing for Serbia in the United Cup last week and needed treatment twice during a quarterfinal loss to Australia's Alex de Minaur.

"My wrist is good. I had time from the last match against de Minaur to my first match here to recover," he said. "I've been training well. Practice sessions are pain-free so far. It's good. It's all looking good."

Djokovic has made it a habit to start the year with a title in Australia. He's on a 28-match winning streak at Melbourne Park, where he has won an unprecedented 10 men's singles crowns. It's a major contributor to his record 24 Grand Slam titles.

And he feels right at home. He hosted "A Night with Novak and Friends" that drew almost a capacity crowd to Rod Laver Arena, where he got the jump on organizers by announcing he'd be playing the night match on Sunday — Day 1 of the first-ever 15-day Australian Open.

Both singles champions will play in the first of the night sessions: Djokovic's opener against qualifier Dino Prizmic will be followed by Aryna Sabalenka's first-round match against Ella Seidel.

Fourth-seeded Jannik Sinner, who beat Djokovic twice in a month late last year, including in Italy's run to the Davis Cup title, will open play on the main show court against Botic van de Zandschulp. That match will be followed by No. 8 Maria Sakkari's women's first round against Nao Hibino. Caroline Wozniacki, the 2018 champion who is returning to Melbourne Park for the first time as a mother, will open the night session at Margaret Court Arena.

The first round will be staged over three days, with organizers hoping to cut back on the late finishes across the tournament.

Djokovic won 27 of his 28 matches in Grand Slams last year, losing only the Wimbledon final to Carlos Alcaraz. He's determined to go one better than that in 2024 and would like an Olympic gold medal in Paris to go with it.

Asked Saturday if the so-called Golden Slam — all four majors plus Olympic gold — was in his reckoning for this season, Djokovic said it's no secret that he wants to win every major he contests.

"It's no different this year," he said. "I'm just hoping I can start the season in a way that I have been starting my seasons, most of my seasons, throughout my career: with a win here in Australia, in Melbourne. My favourite place, no doubt."

Djokovic has won four of the last five Australian titles — the only one he missed was the one he wasn't allowed to contest. He was deported from Australia on the eve of the 2022 tournament because he wasn't vaccinated for COVID-19.

That's why he considers his victory last year, capped with a straight-sets win over Stefanos Tsitsipas, his best.

Alcaraz is seeded No. 2 in Australia, and so can only face Djokovic here if they both make the final. The chance to beat Djokovic at Rod Laver Arena is one the 20-year-old Spaniard would savour.

Alcaraz missed the Australian Open last year and then lost to Djokovic in the French Open semi-finals before his victory at Wimbledon gave him a second career major.

Djokovic had won the title in the four previous Wimbledon campaigns he'd entered.

The 36-year-old Serbian star is staying well-grounded in the routines that have delivered unprecedented results at Melbourne Park.

That, he said, would include visits to the Botanical Gardens on the opposite bank of the Yarra River to Melbourne Park.

"I'm not superstitious. I do like to visit certain places that have brought me luck and make me feel good," he said. "For example, the botanical gardens, it's a wonderful park where I like to spend time and just be by myself in nature, just grounding, hugging trees, climbing trees and stuff. I love to do that."

He won his first Grand Slam title in Australia in 2008, and the back-to-nature concept has been a theme here ever since.



PHOTO: ANDY WONG VIA AP
Novak Djokovic serves during a practice session ahead of the Australian Open tennis championships at Melbourne Park in Australia, Saturday, Jan. 13, 2024.

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:29 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 18 - 20°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.8	6.2	0.0
Dipayal	19.5	4.7	0.0
Dhangadi	16.7	10.0	0.0
Birendranagar	21.2	5.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	17.0	10.8	0.0
Jumla	21.0	-3.9	0.0
Ghorahi	22.6	7.7	0.0
Pokhara	21.2	7.3	0.0
Bhairahawa	16.0	7.0	0.0
Simara	15.5	11.5	0.0
Kathmandu	19.8	4.6	0.0
Okhaldhunga	18.7	8.5	0.0
Taplejung	19.2	5.2	0.0
Dhankuta	23.7	8.0	0.0
Biratnagar	15.6	10.0	0.0
Jomsom	15.0	0.0	0.0*
Dharan	18.5	8.5	0.0*
Lumle	17.9	5.7	0.0*
Janakpur	21.0	12.4	0.0*
Jiri	17.9	0.1	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 14, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.38	Rs. 132.98
Euro	1	Rs. 145.01	Rs. 145.67
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.69	Rs. 169.45
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.05	Rs. 155.75
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.56	Rs. 88.96
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.02	Rs. 99.47
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.41	Rs. 99.86
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.12	Rs. 9.16
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.47	Rs. 18.55
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.30	Rs. 35.46
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.29	Rs. 36.46
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.77	Rs. 3.79
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.04	Rs. 36.21
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.48	Rs. 28.61
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.07	Rs. 10.12
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.87	Rs. 12.93
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.45	Rs. 19.53
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.92	Rs. 17.00
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.77	Rs. 432.72
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.14	Rs. 352.73

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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